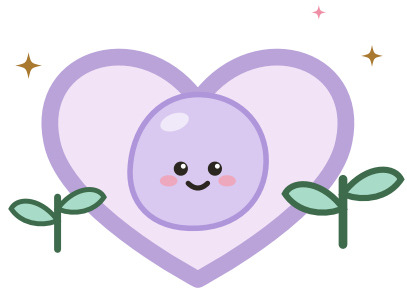
SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 2

Heal and Steady

Stress, anger, worry, loss and repair, and finding your footing again



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 2: *Heal and Steady*.
By Christian. Published by Christian's Lab, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

Text and pictures © 2026 Christian. First print edition, October 2026. Printed on demand.

ISBN: [to be added] (paperback)

Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

Set in Lora, Fraunces and IBM Plex Mono.

Contents

About this book, and how to use it 4

Find it fast 5

Workpapers, tools and three friends 6

If you need help now 7

1 Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery 9

2 Anger: what it's for and what to do with it 31

3 Worry, low mood and trauma 51

4 Loss, grief and big life changes 73

5 Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help 89

6 Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work 107

7 Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life 125

Questions people ask 140

Workpapers and tools in this book 142

Words used in this book 145

Research notes 148

Free on the website 156

The Logic Behind It: more examples 158

The series 159

Your notes 160

About this book, and how to use it

This book is for the heavy days. It covers stress, sleep and rest, anger, worry, low mood and trauma, grief, repair after hurt, the slow work of change, and what matters to you.

It is for anyone going through a hard stretch, and for anyone standing beside someone who is. Each chapter says plainly when it is time to get help from a doctor, counsellor or helpline, and how to find one.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Stress and the nervous system	…/book/understanding-2-stress
Chapter 2	Anger	…/book/understanding-13-anger
Chapter 3	Worry, low mood and trauma	…/book/understanding-16-worry
Chapter 4	Loss, grief and big life changes	…/book/understanding-8-loss
Chapter 5	Healing after hurt	…/book/understanding-11-healing
Chapter 6	Habits and change	…/book/understanding-6-change
Chapter 7	Values, meaning and a good life	…/book/understanding-10-values

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 1, *Know Yourself Kindly*, about yourself; Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, about understanding the people around you; Book 4, *Share the Load*, about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 1, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Find it fast

Start with what is going on. Each line points to the chapter that helps most, and you can read that chapter on its own.

You feel flooded and can't think straight	Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system	9
Small things make you snap	Chapter 2 · Anger	31
Worry keeps you awake	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	51
Your mood has been low for weeks	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	51
Something frightening happened and it hasn't left you	Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma	51
Someone has died, or life changed all at once	Chapter 4 · Loss, grief and big life changes	73
You hurt someone, or someone hurt you	Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt	89
You keep starting good habits and dropping them	Chapter 6 · Habits and change	107
You've lost sight of what matters to you	Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life	125

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-02 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-02: How much are you carrying?”. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music”. You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Book 3, Chapter 7, page 119 says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Chapter 3, page **68** about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 1

Stress and the nervous system: the ladder, flooding, rest and recovery

What stress does to your body and your mind, why kind people say things they don't mean when they are flooded, and the kinds of rest that actually help you recover.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Stress is your body getting ready
2. Stress depends on what you have to meet it
3. The ladder: three everyday states
4. When you're flooded, thinking goes offline
5. Stress adds up, like a tank filling
6. Settle the body first
7. Rest isn't one thing
8. Sleep and stress feed each other
9. Stress is easier to carry when it's shared
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Stress is your body getting ready** for a demand. A little helps you rise to it, but too much for too long wears you down.
- **You move between three everyday states** through the day, calm and connected, revved up and running on empty, and each one changes how you think and hear.
- **When you are flooded, careful thinking goes offline**, so pause, let your body settle and come back at a set time.

- **Rest is a skill.** Different kinds of tired need different kinds of rest, and sleep matters more than most people think.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Several tools in other chapters lean on what this one explains.

- **How much are you carrying? and the stress tank** (Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51)) work because stress adds up from many small loads. A full tank makes small things feel big, so you check the tank before you judge the moment.
- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Book 1, Chapter 2 (page 25)) settles the body before any words, because a flooded body can't think or listen. Its rule about coming back at a set time keeps a pause from looking like walking out.
- **The setup score** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) counts stress as well as hours, because a split that looks fair on paper can still leave one person running on empty.

MONDAY, 7:52AM

The bus is late, the kids can't find a shoe, and your phone buzzes with a work message. Your partner says, "Have you seen my keys?" and you hear yourself snap, "I'm not your secretary!" A second later you wonder where that came from, because the keys were never the problem and you were already running late before anyone spoke.

Feelings are the subject of Book 1, Chapter 4 (page 61). This chapter looks at the system underneath them, your nervous system, and what happens to it under pressure. Understanding stress won't

make a busy life any quieter, but it can make your own reactions, and other people's, a lot less mysterious.

01

Stress is your body getting ready.

When something needs dealing with, your body gears up. The heart speeds up, breathing quickens, muscles tense and stress hormones rise. That is useful when you need to catch a falling glass, meet a deadline or speak up in a meeting. The trouble starts when the body stays geared up for too long and never gets the chance to come back down.

For example, a nurse handles an emergency calmly and well. Two hours later, at home, she can't sit still and finds herself crying at an advert for car insurance, because her body is still running the emergency.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "My body is getting ready for something, and that's its job."
> "The emergency is over. I can let my body catch up."

TRY THIS.

After something stressful, give your body a clear signal that it's over, such as a walk round the block, a shower, a stretch or one song played loud.

02

Stress depends on what you have to meet it.

The same event can be easy for one person and huge for another. Stress grows when a demand looks bigger than what you have to meet it, whether that is time, energy, money, help, skill or sleep. That is why a small thing can tip you over on a bad day, and why giving someone more support can shrink their stress without changing the task at all.

Two coworkers get the same tight deadline on a Thursday. One has a quiet evening ahead, and the other has a child at home with a temperature and a partner away for work. On paper it is one task, yet one of them will lie awake over it.

YOU COULD SAY

"It's less the task than how little I have left today." "What would make this feel more doable?"

THIS WEEK.

When something feels huge, write two lists side by side, one for what it asks of you and one for what you have. Then ask what could make the second list a little longer.

03

The ladder: three everyday states.

The ladder is a picture for three states your body moves between during the day. When you are **calm and connected**, breathing is easy and you can hear hard things. When you are **revved up**, you feel fast and tense, and small things seem urgent or personal. When you are **running on empty**, you feel flat and slow and short of words.

Most people move up and down the ladder many times a day. The Nervous System Ladder is a thirty-second self-check that gives you a best guess at where you are right now.

For example, a grandfather minding his toddler granddaughter all afternoon is calm at two o'clock, revved up by four and running on empty by six. Neither of them has changed, only the hour and how much of the day is left in him.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm revved up right now." "I'm running on empty. Can this wait till morning?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Set three reminders on your phone for today. Each time one goes off, notice which rung you are on, and leave it at noticing.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The ladder (the sky, in My weather today)

Mike, who cares for his wife, Ann

The sky

Pick the one closest to true right now. This is a reading of you, never of anyone else.

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · Gusty: Revved up · *Fogged in: Running on empty*

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · Coworkers · *Someone I care for* · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · Building · *Heavy*

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · About enough · Properly rested

What's blowing in

Work · Money · *Kids or caring* · *Health* · Family · The house · One conversation · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · *Rest* · To move · To be heard · A plan · Company · Quiet · *Someone to take something off me*

YOUR FORECAST

Fogged in today
Running on empty · Very little room today

Talk window
another day is kinder

You were already carrying a heavy day before this. Treat the size of your reaction as a reading on the day, not on whoever is in front of you.

Between you and the person you care for today: do the essentials kindly and let the rest go. If anyone can cover one thing today, ask them.

If you need to say something now: “I’m at the end of what I can carry today. Could you take [one thing] off me?”

A heavy reading is information about a day, not a failing in a person.

Fill in your own: My weather today: the sky

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

04

When you’re flooded, thinking goes offline.

At the top of the stress curve the body is in full alarm, and careful thinking, listening and seeing the other side all get much harder. Many people call this being **flooded**. You might say things you don’t mean, freeze, or only want to get out of the room. A flooded

person is still a decent person whose body needs to come down before the talk can go anywhere useful.

Two adult siblings start sorting their late father's things. Within minutes they are shouting about a lamp that neither of them wants, while the real subject, that he is gone, sits unspoken in the boxes around them.

YOU COULD SAY

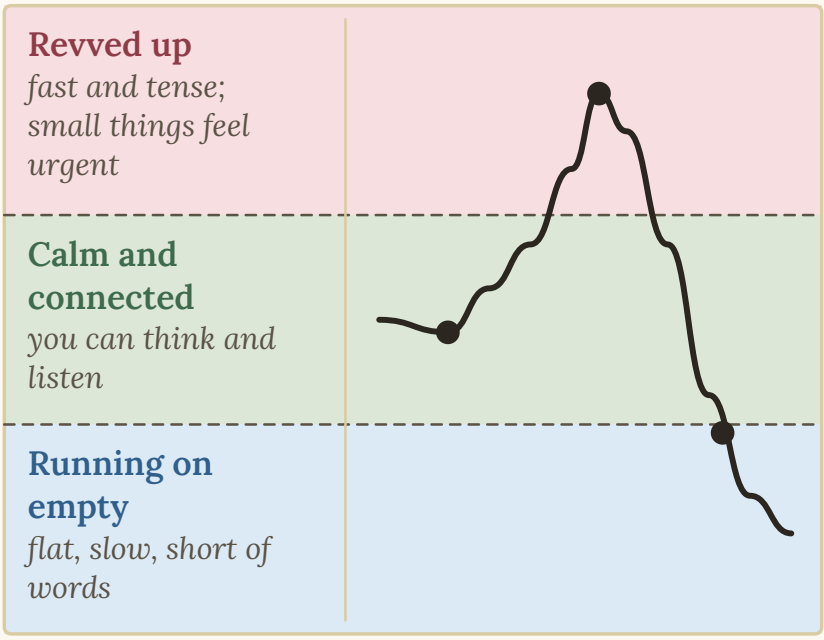
"I'm too flooded to listen well. Can we stop for twenty minutes and come back at four?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Learn your own flood signs, such as heat in your face, a racing heart, narrowed vision or a loud inner voice. When you notice two of them at once, pause.

The ladder: three everyday states

You move up and down it all day.



Same grandfather, same toddler. The state changed.

Hard talks go best from the middle band.

Everyday words, not a medical model. A related map is the "window of tolerance" (Siegel, 1999): inside it, you can feel strongly and still think.

FIGURE 1 The ladder: three everyday states. You move up and down it all day; hard talks go best from the middle band.

05

Stress adds up, like a tank filling.

Think of a tank that holds all the stress you are already carrying today. Stress from one place spills into the next, so traffic, a hard meeting, a noisy shop and a worrying text all fill the same tank. By evening a tiny thing makes it overflow. The last drop gets the blame even though the tank was nearly full already, and small daily hassles count as much as big events.

For example, a teenager explodes when asked to empty the dishwasher. His mum later finds out that his closest friendship fell apart at lunchtime, and the dishwasher simply happened to be the next thing anyone asked of him.

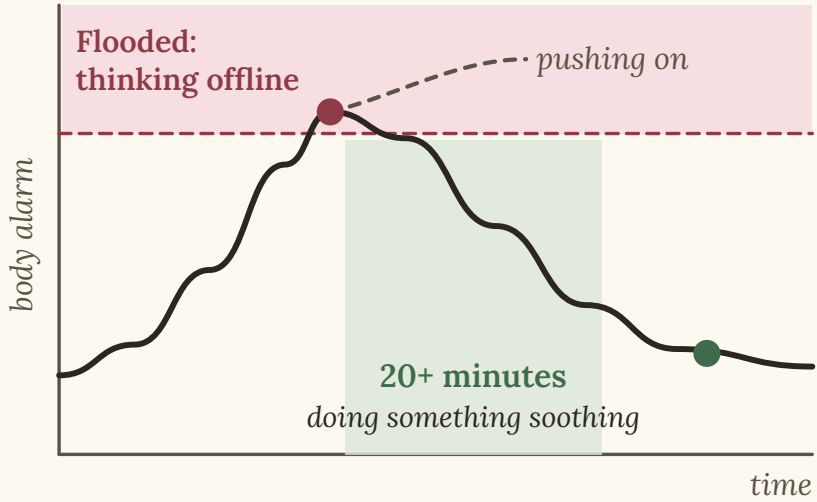
> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "My tank was already full when I got home, and that wasn't really about you." "Rough day? You don't have to explain."

TRY THIS.

Before you react to a small thing in the evening, ask yourself how full you were before it happened. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51) has a simple way to tell.

Flooded means offline

Pause, settle, then come back.



- Pause, and name a time to come back.
- Settle the body. Don't rehearse the argument.
- Come back and talk, once you can listen.

Illustrative curve. John Gottman's work on couples suggests a real break of at least about twenty minutes when flooded.

FIGURE 2 Flooded means offline. Pause and name a time to come back, settle the body for at least twenty minutes, then talk. Illustrative curve.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Stress fills up a little at a time, like a puddle in a long shower of rain. I would know. Five quick questions tell you how full yours is today.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · free to print · spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

06

Settle the body first.

You can't think your way out of a body in alarm, but you can help the body come down, and the thinking usually follows. Slow breathing with long out-breaths helps many people. So does moving, humming a familiar song, steady pressure such as a heavy blanket, or simply leaving a noisy room. What works differs from person to person, so it is worth finding your own short list on a calm day.

A manager feels her heart race before she has to give some hard feedback. She walks once round the block, breathing out slowly, and goes into the room a little steadier than she would have been.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Body first, words second." "What has helped me settle before?"

THIS WEEK.

On a calm day, list three things that settle you and keep the list on your phone. The Calm-Down Kit helps you build it.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

07

Rest isn't one thing.

An hour on the sofa scrolling your phone may leave you more tired than before. Recovery comes in different kinds. There is sleep, there is switching off from work in your head, there is real relaxation, there is doing something absorbing that you enjoy, and there is the feeling of being in charge of your own time. Being with people restores some people and drains others, so the right rest depends on the kind of tired you are.

For example, two housemates plan a relaxing Saturday with friends round. One of them wakes up on Sunday refreshed, and the other needs the whole of Sunday alone with a book before she feels like herself again.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I need quiet rest tonight rather than people rest. It isn't about you." "What kind of tired are you?"

ONE SMALL STEP.
Ask yourself whether you are body-tired, people-tired, brain-tired or feelings-tired, and pick a rest that matches.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: rest can be a nap, a walk or ten minutes of soft music. Find the kind that suits you, and keep it close.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

08

Sleep and stress feed each other.

Stress makes sleep harder, and poor sleep makes stress hit harder. After a short or broken night, small things feel bigger, tempers are shorter and people pull away from each other. In a brain-scan study by Yoo and colleagues (2007), one night without sleep made the brain's alarm centre react more strongly to upsetting pictures.

In a daily study by Gordon and Chen (2014), people reported more conflict with their partner after nights of poor sleep. And in experiments by Ben Simon and Walker (2018), people who had missed a night's sleep kept others at a greater distance and felt lonelier. You can't always fix sleep, but you can notice when it is part of the story.

A nurse coming off three night shifts finds herself in tears over a parking ticket. Her sister says, "You've barely slept. Let's sort it out on Thursday." By Thursday it is a parking ticket again, annoying and payable.

YOU COULD SAY

"I slept badly, so if I'm short with you today, that's why." "Can we talk about this after we've both slept?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Before a hard conversation, ask whether you have both slept, and if not, pick another time. At night, try the same few calm steps before bed in the same order, so your body learns the signal. If poor sleep goes on for weeks, talk to a doctor, because sleep problems are common and often treatable.

09

Stress is easier to carry when it's shared.

People calm each other. A steady voice, a hand on the shoulder or just a quiet person nearby can help a nervous system settle. Saying your state out loud also helps others read you right, because "I'm stressed about work" stops a partner or friend from wondering whether it is about them. Sharing stress in this way lets someone stand beside you without asking them to carry it for you.

For example, a father tells his ten-year-old, "I'm a bit stressed about money this month. Sorting it is my grown-up job, and you're not in trouble." Over the next few days his son stops tiptoeing round him and starts asking for help with his homework again.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm stressed, and it isn't about you." "Would a hug help, or some space?"

TRY THIS.

Tonight, tell one person your state in one sentence, and ask how they are.

MONDAY, 7:58AM

Six minutes after the snap, you find your partner by the door, still patting their pockets. "Sorry. My tank was full before you said a word, and your keys are on the bathroom shelf." They laugh and ask whether it has been a rough start. The bus is still late and the shoe is still missing, but the two of you are on the same side of the morning again.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Snapping when hungry or tired

FROM OUTSIDE A small question at the end of a long day gets a sharp answer.

THE LOGIC Patience runs on fuel → Hunger and tiredness drain the tank → With an empty tank, small things feel big → The snap is the fuel gauge talking

IT'S LIKE A phone on 3% that starts closing apps.

WHY IT FITS Poor sleep is linked with more conflict the next day, and hunger can colour our judgements without our noticing.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who asked did nothing wrong, and the tone still lands on them.

YOU COULD SAY *"I'm running on empty. Can we talk after I've eaten?"*

ONE SMALL STEP Eat first. Then come back and say sorry for the tone.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=hungry-tired-snap

In everyday life

If you live on your own, nobody is there to notice when you are running on empty, so it helps to build rest into the week before you need it. With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day, along with the rule that whoever pauses names a time to come back (One of you wants to talk now, the other needs space has

more on this). A child can't settle until the nearest grown-up does, which means your calm is something they borrow long before they learn it for themselves. At work, a flooded colleague can't take in feedback, and waiting an hour often works better than pushing on.

Some people run on empty for reasons built into their lives, such as shift work, long-term illness or caring for someone. That calls for a different setup rather than more effort (see Different hours and Caregivers). If you have ADHD, keeping track of everything can quietly fill the tank before the day has started. It helps to move the remembering out of your head with a shared list, labelled alarms and one place for keys, and to plan hard talks for your better time of day. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: make a pause plan
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance.com/different-hours

ONLINE
Caregivers
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

Common mix-ups

- **"All stress is bad."** Short bursts of stress help you rise to a challenge. The harm comes from stress that never gets a recovery.
- **"If I'm calm, I can't be upset."** Calm means steady. You can be calm and sad, or calm and firm.
- **"Pausing is avoiding."** A pause with a time to come back is a way to finish the talk well. Avoiding is the pause that never comes back.
- **"Rest is lazy."** Recovery is part of the work, and bodies and minds that never recover tend to break down.
- **"Running on empty means they don't care."** Short replies and a flat face more often mean someone is worn out.

If you want to help someone else with this

A lower voice, slower words and a steady presence help a stressed person more than being told to calm down. Taking one task off someone's list can do more than any pep talk, so ask what kind of help they want, whether practical help, company, a distraction or some space, rather than guessing. Don't debate with someone who is flooded. Offer a break and a time to come back, because the facts will still be there in twenty minutes. And if someone has been running on empty for weeks, mention it gently and help them find support.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "You seem really stretched. Is there one thing I could take off your plate?" "We don't have to sort this now. Shall we pick it up after dinner?"

When to get more help

Stress is normal. Constant stress that never lets up is a warning sign. It may be time to see a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional if:

- you've felt exhausted, dread-filled or numb most days for several weeks, even after rest;
- you can't sleep, or sleep but never feel rested;
- you have physical signs that worry you, such as chest pain, constant headaches or stomach trouble (always get chest pain checked straight away);
- you're relying on alcohol, drugs or other habits to get through the day;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that is happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line.

If the stress comes from being afraid of someone, such as how they will react, what they will do or whether you are allowed to leave, that is not ordinary stress. Your body may be warning you. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not medical advice or diagnosis.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers pages you fill in, on your own or together

- The Calm-Down Kit: your plan for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools helpers you use on the website

- The Nervous System Ladder: a thirty-second self-check.
- Upset right now?: steps to calm down, alone or together.
- Drift, Brain Breakers and calm games: gentle ways to come down.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
Drift
spreadloveandacceptance.com/calm-visualizer



TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes



ONLINE
calm games
spreadloveandacceptance.com/pause-and-play

More for your situation

- Book 4, Chapter 3: full tanks and different angles (page 51)
- How to stop fighting: calm steps
- New baby, sharing the load and Coming home after time apart
- For teens: big feelings and stress
- Sensory overload at home
- Help by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
How to stop fighting: calm steps
spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-to-stop-fighting-with-your-partner

ONLINE
New baby, sharing the load
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
For teens: big feelings and stress
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Sensory overload at home
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank in a shared home
Share the Load, page 51

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Your weather before you speak
Know Yourself Kindly, page 25

Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune
How stress knocks two people out of tune
Understanding Each Other, page 9

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When stress turns into worry or low mood
page 51

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: Your plan for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
A thirty-second self-check
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-2-stress-in-depth

2

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 2

Anger: what it's for and what to do with it

What anger is for, what to do in the hot minutes, how to repair afterwards, and how to tell when anger has turned into harm. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Anger is a signal about something that matters
2. Anger often guards a softer feeling
3. Anger rises in the body fast
4. In the hot minutes: slow the body first
5. Letting rip doesn't empty it
6. Step back and look from the outside
7. Say it, don't throw it
8. After anger, repair
9. When anger becomes harm
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **The Calm-Down Kit** (Book 1, Chapter 2 (page 25)) works because anger rises in the body first, and slowing the body is what makes words possible.
- **Letting a comment land before you react** (Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 71)) is the step back this chapter describes, where you look at the moment from the outside and then choose.

TUESDAY, 6:10PM

Your brother texts to say he can't take Mum to the hospital on Thursday after all, with two exclamation marks after the sorry. It's the third time this month. Your jaw sets, your face goes hot and your thumbs are already typing "TYPICAL. You never..." with the message one tap from sent.

Many of us were taught that anger was rude or dangerous, or grew up around anger that was frightening. Anger itself is a normal human feeling, though, and it often points at something real. This chapter looks first at how anger works and then at what to do with it.

01

Anger is a signal about something that matters.

Anger usually says that something is unfair, that someone is in your way or that a line has been crossed. It pushes us *towards* a problem so that we change it. It can also land on the wrong person, or be far bigger than the problem in front of it.

For example, a woman keeps finding her lunch gone from the office fridge. By the third week her anger has told her that a line has been crossed, and it is the anger that finally gets her to raise it at the Monday meeting.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What is this anger trying to protect?" "Is this about fairness, a blocked plan or feeling unsafe?"

TRY THIS.

Next time you feel angry, finish this sentence privately. “I’m angry because something I care about, which is ___, seems ___.”

02

Anger often guards a softer feeling.

Anger can arrive first because it feels stronger and safer than what sits under it, which might be hurt, fear, shame, worry or plain tiredness. Book 1, Chapter 4 (page 61) calls this layers. Finding the layer underneath often shows what you actually need.

A man snaps at his teenage daughter for coming home an hour late. Under the anger is an hour of fear spent imagining the worst. When he tells her about that hour instead of the curfew, she hears it and says sorry.

YOU COULD SAY

“I’m angry, and I think underneath I was really scared.” “I came across cross, but I think I’m actually hurt.”

THIS WEEK.

After the next angry moment, once you are calm, ask whether there was hurt, fear or tiredness under it.

03

Anger rises in the body fast.

A hot face, a tight jaw, a pounding heart and a louder voice are the body getting ready for a fight, and they can arrive in seconds. When anger is high, careful thinking and listening get much harder. Chapter 1 (page 9) calls this being flooded, when you are so stirred up that the thinking part of you goes quiet for a while.

For example, arguing about the bins, a woman notices her hands shaking and realises she hasn't heard a word her housemate has said for a minute or more, which is her sign to stop.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"My body is ready for a fight, but I don't have to have one."
"Where is this in my body?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Learn your own early signs and write down two or three of them, such as a tight jaw or talking faster. They are your cue to slow down.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Anger moves faster than words. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make on a calm day, for the hot minutes.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

04

In the hot minutes: slow the body first.

When anger is high, settle your body before you try to sort anything out. Stop talking or typing, breathe out slowly so the out-breath is longer than the in-breath, unclench your hands and, if you can, move away for a while. A large review of 154 studies by

Kjærvik and Bushman (2024) found that activities which calm the body, like slow breathing, relaxation and mindfulness, reduced anger, while ones that rev you up showed little or no benefit.

A dad feels his temper rising while he helps with fractions homework. He says, "I'm getting frustrated, and that's not your fault. I'm going to get a glass of water and come back in five minutes." He comes back in five, and they finish the sheet together.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm too angry to talk well right now. I'll come back at eight." "I need ten minutes. I'm coming back to this conversation."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

On a calm day, make a three-step plan with your early sign, the words you'll say and where you'll go for ten minutes. Upset right now? has steps for the hottest moments.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

The Calm-Down Kit

Pat, a grandmother raising her grandson Jay, 13

The Calm-Down Kit

Whose kit is this? (your name)
Pat (Nan)

Date
4 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
Door slammed after a call with his mum	*Shoulders up by my ears*
Being shouted at in front of the neighbours	*Hot face, can't find words*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Gating (lower the lights, step out)

Second, if the first isn't available
Low, steady sound

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm too wound up to listen well. I'm putting the kettle on for twenty minutes. I'll come and find you at half past.

Our pause plan (agree it together, and share it)

Our pause word or signal
"Kettle time"

The shortest break we take
20 minutes

How we set the time to come back
Whoever pauses says a time before they go

The first sentence when we come back
"I'm back. Let's start again, slower."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
5:10 pm	*Gating (lower the lights, step out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: go back to the conversation, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Sit with Jay and agree one screen-time rule

If you put the conversation off: when you'll pick it back up
After tea, at 6

☑ I'm going with this

Jay agreed the pause plan with her on a calm Sunday. "Gating", one of the kit's calming steps, means cutting down what comes in through the senses: lower the lights, turn the sound down, or step out of the room.

Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

05

Letting rip doesn't empty it.

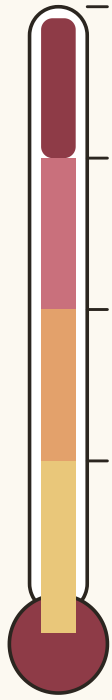
Many people believe anger works like steam, so that shouting, slamming a door or hitting a pillow lets it out and leaves you calmer. Research doesn't support this. In a well-known study by Bushman (2002), angry people who hit a punching bag while thinking about the person who annoyed them ended up angrier than before.

Going over what happened again and again in your head has a similar effect. In studies by Bushman and colleagues (2005), people who dwelt on a provocation were later more aggressive, even towards someone who only mildly annoyed them. Anger tends to

fade faster when the body is calmed and the mind has something else to do for a while.

Anger rises fast

What helps depends on how hot it is.



Hot minutes
Slow the body first: long out-breaths. Step away, with a time to come back.

Angry
Don't solve it now. Problems can wait; sharp words are hard to take back.

Annoyed
Notice the body: hot face, tight jaw, clenched hands.

Irritated
Say it early, plainly and kindly.

✕ **Letting rip doesn't empty it. It feeds it.**

Once cooler: say it, don't throw it.
Then repair any sharp moments.

In a review of 154 studies (Kjærvik and Bushman, 2024), activities that calm the body reduced anger; revving it up did not help. If anger frightens or controls someone, safety comes first.

FIGURE 3 Anger rises fast, and what helps depends on how hot it is. In the hot minutes, slow the body first; letting rip feeds it.

For example, after a row with a coworker, a man spends his lunch break telling three people how awful she is, and by the afternoon he is angrier than he was at noon. The next time it happens he takes a walk instead, and by two o'clock he can think about the problem clearly.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"Going over this again is feeding it." "I can come back to this later, when I'm calmer."

TRY THIS.

If you catch yourself replaying an argument, set a timer for twenty minutes and do something absorbing, then come back to the problem.

06

Step back and look from the outside.

Once the body has settled a little, it helps to look at the moment as if you were watching from across the room. What happened, and what might the other person have been dealing with? In experiments by Mischkowski, Kross and Bushman (2012), people who looked back on an annoying moment "like a fly on the wall", instead of reliving it, felt less angry and acted less aggressively. Rethinking what happened, which psychologists call reappraisal (Gross, 1998), helps too.

Furious that a friend has cancelled again, a woman imagines telling the story to a kind stranger on a train. Telling it that way, she remembers that her friend is caring for a sick parent, and the anger turns slowly into worry for her.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"If I were watching this from the side, what would I see?" "What else might be going on for them?"

THIS WEEK.

Write two lines about the moment that start with your own name in place of "I", as in "Wes got angry because..."

07

Say it, don't throw it.

Anger is often a fair message sent in a hurtful way. Once you are calmer, you can still say that you were angry, and why, without attacking anyone. A simple shape helps. Say what happened, how you felt and what you are asking for.

For example, in place of "You always let me down," a woman says to her sister, "When you cancelled Mum's appointment again, I felt really angry and alone with it. Can we make a plan for who takes her over the next three months?"

YOU COULD SAY

"I was angry about what happened on Monday. Can I tell you why?" "When ___ happened, I felt ___, and what I'm asking for is ___."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Write your angry message, then rewrite it in that shape before you send anything. Book 3, Chapter 2 (page 27) has more on saying hard things.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: say it slowly, in one plain sentence. A soft start makes it easier for the other person to hear you.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
soften a tense moment
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/tools/
soften-a-tense-moment

08

After anger, repair.

Everyone gets angry, and most of us say something sharp now and then. What happens next matters a great deal. A short, real repair helps rebuild trust, which means naming what you did without a "but" and saying what you will do differently.

A grandmother shouts at her grandson for breaking a vase, and he cries. An hour later she sits beside him on the stairs and says, "I shouted, and that was scary. You matter far more to me than the vase. I'm sorry." He leans against her shoulder and asks whether they can glue it.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I was sharp with you earlier. That wasn't fair, and I'm sorry."
> "I'm still upset about what happened, and I also shouldn't have spoken to you that way."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Think of one recent moment when your anger landed on someone. Is there a short repair you could still make? Chapter 5 (page 89) has more on apologies that land.

09

When anger becomes harm.

Feeling angry is human. But some things done in anger are harm, whatever the feeling behind them: hitting, pushing, throwing things at or near someone, breaking their things, threatening, shouting so someone is scared, or using anger to control what another person does, wears, spends or who they see. People walking on eggshells around you is a sign too. Anger is never a reason someone deserves to be hurt.

For example, a man realises his partner and children go quiet when he comes home in a bad mood. He doesn't hit anyone, but they are afraid of him. He talks to his doctor and joins an anger course.

YOU COULD SAY

"I think my anger is scaring people I love. I want help with it." (If it's happening to you) "I'm frightened of how they get when they're angry."

TRY THIS.

If this sounds like you, see Find a counsellor or therapist and the Cool-down corner. If you're afraid of someone else's anger, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn your early signs, settle your body, say what made you angry in words, and repair when you get it wrong. You can't make someone else calm down, and you don't have to accept being shouted at, threatened or controlled. If someone else's anger frightens you, getting safe matters more than working it out. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

TUESDAY, 6:40PM

You put the phone face down and walk round the block, breathing out long. Somewhere near the postbox you notice what is under the anger. You are tired, and you are frightened about Mum. Back home you delete the capitals and write, "I'm really frustrated. This is the third time and I feel alone with Mum's care. Can we talk tonight and make a plan?"

He reads it at 6:52. By ten o'clock there is still no reply, and you go to bed not knowing who will drive her on Thursday. You sent the message you can stand behind, and that part is done, even if the rest of it isn't.

If you're a teenager

Maisie is sixteen, and her dad takes her phone at ten o'clock in the middle of a chat with her friends. She shouts and slams her bedroom door. The next morning, calmer, she tells him it felt as if he didn't trust her, says sorry for the door and asks for ten minutes' warning next time. He agrees, and adds that he would rather hear this over breakfast than through a door.

Being angry with a parent is normal, and arguments often feel most intense in the middle teens. A rule given out of care is not control, even when it feels unfair, and a calm request the next day works more often than a slammed door.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I'm too angry to talk properly. Can we talk tomorrow?" "I don't mind the rule so much as how it happened." "Could we try it for two weeks and then check?"

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Getting upset over something "small"

FROM OUTSIDE After a long day, a cup left on the side leads to an outburst.

THE LOGIC Stress adds up all day → Each thing fills a glass a little more → The cup is the last drop → What spills is the whole glass

IT'S LIKE One more breath into a balloon that was already full.

WHY IT FITS The last small thing often gets the reaction that belongs to the whole day.

THE OTHER SIDE The person who left the cup gets a whole day poured over them.

YOU COULD SAY *"It's not just the cup. It's been a heavy day."*

ONE SMALL STEP Say early when the glass is getting full. Afterwards, apologise for the size of the reaction.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=last-straw

In everyday life

Anger at yourself counts too. "I'm so stupid" is anger turned inward, and it helps to speak to yourself as you would to a friend who had made the same mistake (Book 1, Chapter 5 (page 81) goes further). With a partner, agree a pause word on a calm day and a time you will always come back. Children copy what we do with anger far more than what we say about it. At work, anger is common and rarely said out loud, and "I'm frustrated about the deadline change. Can we talk about what's realistic?" keeps it useful.

If you have ADHD, anger can arrive fast and big and then pass quickly, so plan for the speed with a three-word pause line such as "Back in ten" and a rule to wait before you send anything. If you are managing a clash between two other people, hear each of

them alone first and then together, about what happened and never about each other. The fight is often about the setup, such as two people who both believe they own the same job. The full chapter has a worked example.

Common mix-ups

- **"Anger is a bad feeling."** Anger is a normal feeling that carries information. It is some of the things done in anger that cause harm.
- **"Letting it out is healthy."** Shouting or hitting things tends to keep anger going, and calming the body before talking helps more.
- **"They made me angry, so it's their fault I shouted."** Someone can do something unfair. What you do next is still yours.
- **"Holding it in is the safe option."** Anger swallowed for years tends to come out sideways, as coldness, sarcasm or a sudden explosion. Saying it calmly and early is safer.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Keep yourself safe first.** If someone's anger scares you, step away. You don't have to stay and calm them down.
- **Lower, slower, fewer words.** Speak quietly and simply, and leave the argument until they have come down.
- **Hear the message under it.** There is often something fair under the anger. You can take that part seriously and still say that the way it was said wasn't okay.

YOU COULD SAY

"I want to hear this, and I can't while we're both shouting. Can we try again at seven?" "I can tell this really matters to you."

When to get more help

Everyone gets angry. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or an anger management course if:

- your anger feels out of control, or you often regret what you do or say when angry;
- people close to you seem nervous or walk on eggshells around you;
- you have hit, pushed, thrown things, broken things or threatened anyone;
- anger is hurting your work, your friendships or your health;
- you are using alcohol or drugs to cope with angry feelings.

Help for anger works for many people: a review of anger treatments by Del Vecchio and O'Leary (2004) found medium to large benefits. It is good for your health too: a review by Chida and Steptoe (2009) linked anger and hostility with a higher risk of heart disease. Asking for help is a responsible thing to do. Find a counsellor or therapist lists places to start, some of them free, and the Cool-down corner helps in the hot minutes.

If you are afraid of someone else's anger, that fear is an important signal. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help. If you or anyone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

This chapter is general education, not therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

More for your situation

- For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
- For teens
- Family rifts · Caring for someone you love
- At work

- Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
For parents: help with your own anger · Repair after you've scared a child
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Anger is a signal** that something seems unfair, blocked or threatening. The feeling is allowed, and what you do with it is the part you choose.
- ✓ **The first minutes are about the body.** Slow down, breathe out long, and step away with a time to come back.
- ✓ **Letting rip doesn't empty anger.** Shouting tends to feed it, while calming the body, putting it into words and repairing any sharp moments help more.
- ✓ **Anger that frightens, controls or hurts someone has become harm.** That needs more help, and safety comes first.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
Leftover stress behind a reaction
Share the Load, page 51

Book 1, Chapter 4 · How feelings work
Feelings as signals
Know Yourself Kindly, page 61

Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Repair after the hot minutes
page 89

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
A Calm-Down Kit made on a calm day
Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-13-anger-in-depth

3

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 3

Worry, low mood and trauma

How worry and anxiety work, the difference between a low patch and depression, what trauma is and isn't, what helps day to day, how to support someone, and when and where to get more help. For anyone, in any kind of relationship, or on your own.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm
2. Avoiding keeps fear going
3. Give worry a time and a place
4. Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week
5. Doing often comes before feeling better
6. Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work
7. Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind
8. After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure
9. Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too
10. If you're a teenager
11. In everyday life
12. Common mix-ups
13. If you want to help someone else with this
14. When to get more help
15. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
16. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Worry, low mood and the after-effects of trauma are common, human and treatable.** They are not weakness, and they are not your fault.
- **They all run through the stress system** from Chapter 1 (page 9). Small, steady things that settle the body and reconnect you with life help more than big pushes.

- **Avoiding and withdrawing feel safer but keep things going.** Small steps back in, a little at a time, help most.
- **Talking therapies work for many people, and so can medicines.** If it has lasted weeks, is getting in the way of life, or you feel unsafe, get help. If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (US) or call Samaritans on 116 123 (UK and Ireland) now.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Three tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **The daily check-in's "low, medium or high"** (Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 9)) works because worry and low mood shrink the room you have, and saying so lets the people around you adjust.
- **"A full tank means later, not never"** (Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 51)) names a time to come back, because avoiding a thing keeps fear going and a named time lets you return to it.
- **Pick one small goal** (Book 1, Chapter 3 (page 45)) suits low mood, because doing often comes before feeling better.

SUNDAY, 10:50PM

The house is quiet and you have checked the front door twice. Tomorrow is the hospital appointment, and the same three thoughts keep going round. What if it's bad, what if you can't cope, and what if there is nobody to tell? Your chest is tight and your mind won't stop. If you are honest, you haven't really wanted to see anyone for a few weeks either, and even replying to messages has started to feel like too much effort.

Almost everyone worries, feels low or goes through something frightening at some point. For some people these feelings settle by themselves, and for others they stick and grow until they shape every day. This chapter explains how they work, what tends to help and when it is time to ask for more help. It can't diagnose anyone. If any of this is about you right now, you are not alone, and things can get better.

01

Worry and anxiety are the body's alarm.

Fear is the body's alarm for danger that is here now. Anxiety is the same alarm ringing about something that might happen, and worry is the thinking part, the "What if…?" that plays on repeat. All three run through the stress system described in Chapter 1 (page 9), with a racing heart, a tight chest, shallow breathing, a churning stomach and poor sleep. The alarm is trying to protect you. The trouble is that it can be set too sensitive, and it can't tell a real tiger from a worrying email.

For example, a teenager's heart pounds before every class presentation. Nothing bad has ever happened in one, yet her alarm still treats a room of classmates as if it were dangerous.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "This is my alarm talking, and alarms can be wrong." "My body is getting ready to protect me. I can thank it and carry on."

TRY THIS.

When worry rises, breathe out slowly five times, with each out-breath longer than the in-breath, and then name three things you can see. It tells the body that the danger isn't here right now.

02

Avoiding keeps fear going.

When something makes us anxious, stepping away brings quick relief, and the relief teaches the brain that escaping was a good idea. Next time the fear is a little bigger and the world a little smaller. What helps is going back towards the feared thing in small, chosen steps and staying long enough to learn that you can cope. Therapists call this exposure. Craske and colleagues (2014) describe how it works best when each step tests what you expect to happen.

After a panic attack on a bus, a man starts walking everywhere, even in the rain. With his sister beside him he rides one stop, then two, and some weeks later a whole journey into town, while his brain slowly learns that buses are survivable.

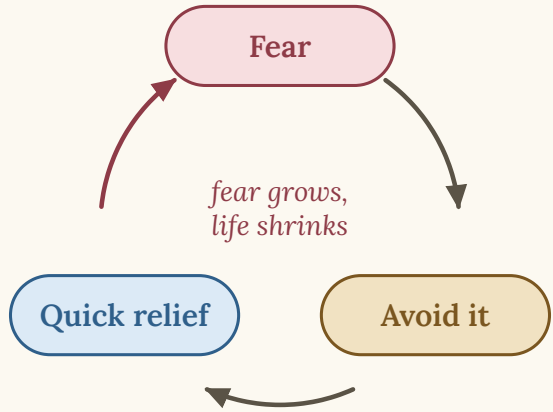
> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
>
> "What do I think will happen? Let's see what actually happens."
> "Uncomfortable isn't the same as dangerous."

THIS WEEK.

Pick one small thing you've been avoiding. Break it into three steps, from easiest to hardest. Do the easiest one this week.

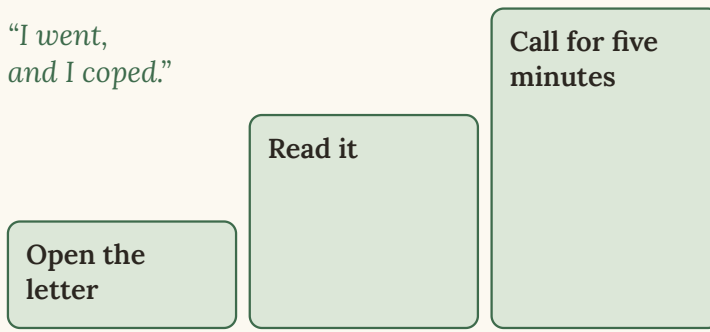
Avoiding keeps fear going

Quick relief now, a smaller life later.



The way back: small, planned steps

*"I went,
and I coped."*



Planned, gradual approach (exposure) is among the most effective treatments for anxiety; it builds new learning that competes with the old fear (Craske and colleagues, 2014). A therapist can help with strong fears.

FIGURE 4 Avoiding keeps fear going. Small, planned steps back in help most, and a therapist can help with strong fears.

03

Give worry a time and a place.

Trying hard not to worry rarely works. What helps many people is postponing it, which means noticing a worry, writing it down and saving it for a set "worry time" later in the day. In an early study by Borkovec and colleagues (1983), people who practised this for four weeks reported worrying less each day. In worry time, ask of each worry whether there is something you can do about it. If there is, plan one step, and if there isn't, practise letting it go.

For example, a father caring for his own dad keeps a worry notebook by the kettle. At six in the evening he gives it fifteen minutes, by which time many of the morning's worries already look smaller.

> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
> "Noted. I'll think about that at six." "Can I do anything about this today? If not, it can wait."

ONE SMALL STEP.
Choose a fifteen-minute worry time well before bed, and keep a note on your phone for worries that pop up in between.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

Flip it

Tolu, 17, at 1am, three days before an exam

Flip it

What's on your mind?

What if I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want?

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone | A *worry* | Being hard on myself | Anger

THE FLIP

The best outcome would be
[what you hope for]

The main thing in the way
I fail my chemistry exam on Friday and don't get into the course I want

If that happens, I'll
[one small thing you could do]

One step today
[something that takes ten minutes or less]

This is WOOP, from Gabriele Oettingen's research: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan. The worry becomes the obstacle you plan for. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Tolu's version

Best outcome: I pass, and I feel I did my best. In the way: I freeze on the long questions. If that happens, I'll do the short questions first and come back. One step today: one long question from a past paper, then bed.

When the worry comes back at 1am
It goes on the list for tomorrow's worry time, 5pm, ten minutes.

If worry is stopping you sleeping or eating most days, tell someone you trust, or your doctor.

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Small wins: Flip it
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

Low mood is common. Depression is more than a bad week.

Everyone has low days, and sadness after a loss or a disappointment is normal. Depression is different. It means low mood, or losing interest in things you used to enjoy, for most of the day, nearly every day, for two weeks or more, often with poor sleep, tiredness, changes in appetite, feeling worthless or guilty, and finding it hard to think. It can look like sadness, or like irritability, numbness or simply running on empty. It is a health problem, and nobody gets it by being weak.

A retired teacher notices he has stopped going to his walking group, isn't reading, and wakes at four every morning. He tells himself he is just getting old, until his daughter gently suggests it might be depression and that depression can be treated.

YOU COULD SAY

"I've not been myself for a few weeks, and I don't think it's just tiredness." "I don't enjoy things I used to. Can I talk to you about it?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

If you've felt low or lost interest most days for two weeks or more, book a talk with a doctor this week. Write down what you've noticed to take with you.

05

Doing often comes before feeling better.

Low mood says to wait until you feel like it. Withdrawing makes life emptier, though, and that deepens the low. A well-tested approach called behavioural activation turns this round. You plan small, doable things that bring a bit of pleasure, meaning or achievement, and you do them whether you feel like it or not. A review of 26 trials by Ekers and colleagues (2014) found it helped with depression, though many of the studies were small.

For example, a woman living alone after her divorce plans three small things a day, a ten-minute walk, one call or message and one task she can finish. Some days they feel pointless, and she does them anyway. Over a few weeks the days begin to feel less flat.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I don't have to feel like it to do it." "Small counts."

TRY THIS.

Write down three tiny things for tomorrow, one for pleasure, one for connection and one you can finish, and tick them off however small they are.

06

Sleep, moving and people do a lot of the work.

These sound too simple to matter, but the evidence for them is solid. Improving sleep can lift mood. In a large trial with university students, Freeman and colleagues (2017) found that an online sleep course reduced insomnia, and with it some other mental health difficulties.

Exercise helps depression too. A review of 218 trials by Noetel and colleagues (2024) found walking or jogging, yoga and strength training all helped. Belonging to groups also protects. Cruwys and colleagues (2013) found that people with depression who joined groups were less likely to relapse.

A new dad, exhausted and flat, agrees with his partner on one protected long sleep each weekend each, a pram walk every morning, and a weekly game of five-a-side.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I need help protecting my sleep for a while." "Would you come for a short walk with me? I find it hard to go on my own."

THIS WEEK.

Pick the one basic that is most off for you right now, sleep, moving or people, and make one small change to it this week.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Small, steady things help: a walk, a regular bedtime, time with someone kind. Calm sounds can be a soft way to wind down at night.

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

07

Trauma is about what happened, and what it left behind.

Trauma usually means going through, or seeing, something that threatened life or safety, such as violence, abuse, a serious accident, war, or the sudden death of someone close. It is very common. In surveys across 24 countries, Kessler and colleagues (2017) found about 7 in 10 adults had been through at least one.

Most people recover over time. A smaller number develop post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), with memories that come back vividly, avoiding reminders, feeling on high alert, and sleep problems. Ordinary hard times and stress hurt too, even when they aren't trauma in this sense.

For example, months after a car crash, a woman still jumps at screeching brakes and avoids driving at night. Her alarm learned that cars can mean danger and has not yet unlearned it, which is a long way from overreacting.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "My reactions make sense after what happened." "It's in the past, even if my body doesn't feel that yet."

ONE SMALL STEP.

If something frightening happened more than a month ago and it still shapes your days, talk to a doctor. Trauma-focused talking therapies help many people.

08

After something frightening: safety, choice and no pressure.

After a frightening event, people need safety, practical help, warmth and choice. They don't need to be made to talk. In fact, a review of single-session "debriefing" after trauma by Rose and colleagues (2002) found it did not prevent PTSD, and might make things worse for some. Services that are "trauma-informed" (SAMHSA, 2014) put safety, trust, choice and working together first. The same ideas help in families, friendships and workplaces.

After a break-in, a grandmother doesn't want to talk about it. Her grandson doesn't push. He fixes the lock, stays the night, and says, "If you ever want to talk about it, I'm here." A week later, she does.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"You don't have to tell me anything. What would help right now?" "You're safe now. I'm staying."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

If someone you love has been through something frightening, ask one practical question ("What do you need today?") and one open one ("How are you doing, really?"), and let them choose.

09

Talking therapies help many people, and medicines can too.

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) teaches practical ways to notice and change patterns of thinking and doing. It is one of the most studied talking therapies, and a review of over a hundred meta-analyses by Hofmann and colleagues (2012) found the strongest support for anxiety problems and stress, and support for many other problems too.

Guidelines such as NICE (2022) also recommend guided self-help, behavioural activation, exercise groups and, for some people, antidepressants. Questions about medicine, including starting, changing or stopping it, are for a doctor or prescriber. Please don't stop a medicine suddenly without advice.

For example, a young man is embarrassed to ask for help with panic attacks. His GP refers him to a short course of CBT, and after eight sessions he is taking the train to work again, with a book and a bottle of water for the bad days.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'd like to talk about my mood. It's been going on for a while."
"What are my options, and what do you recommend for someone like me?"

TRY THIS.

Before an appointment, write three lines about what you have noticed, how long it has lasted and what it is stopping you doing. It makes the first conversation easier.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can learn how your alarm works, keep the basics going, take small steps back towards life, and ask for help when it's more than you can carry. You can't think your way out of depression by trying harder, and you can't fix someone else's. Being kind to yourself, and getting the right help, are part of the work, not a failure at it. If you feel unsafe, reaching out today matters more than anything in this book.

MONDAY, 7:30AM

Last night you wrote the three worries on the back of an envelope and told them they could wait until tomorrow, and you slept a little. This morning you breathe out long at the kitchen window, then text your neighbour. "Hospital at ten. A bit scared. Fancy a cuppa after?"

She replies with three hearts and says of course. The appointment is still the appointment, but you won't be facing it alone. Looking at the envelope again, you notice how many weeks it has been since you felt like yourself, and you add one more line at the bottom, to ask the doctor about your mood as well.

If you're a teenager

Exams, friends, group chats and the future can all pile up, often at one in the morning. Tolu is seventeen and can't sleep before a chemistry exam. She writes the worry down for tomorrow's ten-minute worry time, plans one small step and puts her phone in another room. The next day she tells her mum, and it helps more than she expected.

If worry or low mood is stopping you sleeping, eating or going to school most days for a few weeks, tell someone you trust or your doctor. Under 19 in the UK, you can call Childline free on 0800 1111.

YOU COULD SAY

"I keep worrying at night. Can I talk it through?" "I don't need you to fix it. I just need to say it."

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Asking for reassurance again and again

FROM OUTSIDE "Are you sure you're not angry with me?" for the fourth time tonight.

THE LOGIC Doubt feels like danger → Reassurance turns the alarm off for a moment → Then the alarm comes back → Asking again is trying to turn it off again

IT'S LIKE Going back to check the front door is locked.

WHY IT FITS Uncertainty can feel unbearable when you're anxious, and asking brings real relief, even if it is brief.

THE OTHER SIDE Answering again and again is tiring, and it can keep the loop going.

YOU COULD SAY *"My worry keeps coming back. Asking turns it down for a bit."*

ONE SMALL STEP Agree a kind limit together. One clear answer, then something calming to do side by side. If the worry runs your days, a GP can help.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=reassurance

In everyday life

Living alone can make worry louder at night and low mood quieter and easier to miss, so one small contact a day, a call or a walk with someone, is worth protecting (see On your own: when it's lonely). With a partner, low mood can look like not caring and anxiety can look like nagging, and it helps to name it plainly, as in "I'm low

today, and I'm not cross with you." Children and teenagers get anxious and low too, and calm, routine and listening help them more than reassurance on repeat. A friend who keeps cancelling may be struggling, so keep inviting them, with no pressure to say yes.

Grief and depression overlap without being the same thing, and Chapter 4 (page 73) looks at grief on its own terms. At work, a short, honest line to a manager often opens up more support than people expect. If you have ADHD, avoidance often looks like putting things off, and it helps to make the first step almost silly ("open the envelope"), set a ten-minute timer or do it with someone else in the room. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On your own: when it's lonely
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"Anxiety means something is wrong with me."** Anxiety is a normal alarm. It becomes a problem when it rings too loud or too often, or starts shrinking your life.
- **"Depression is just sadness. Snap out of it."** Depression affects sleep, energy, thinking and body as well as mood. Nobody snaps out of it, but many people recover with the right help.
- **"Everything bad that happens is trauma."** Trauma usually means threat to life or safety. Other hard things still hurt and still deserve care, and the word doesn't need to fit for help to be fair.
- **"Talking about trauma straight away helps everyone."** Some people want to talk, some don't. Forcing it can make things worse. Safety and choice come first.
- **"Asking someone about suicide puts the idea in their head."** It doesn't. A review by Dazzi and colleagues (2014) found no evidence that asking increases suicidal thoughts, and it may help.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Notice and ask.** Something like "You've seemed low lately. How are you doing, really?" opens the door, and then it helps to listen more than you talk.
- **Leave the feeling alone.** "Cheer up" and "It could be worse" push people away, while "That sounds really hard" keeps them close.
- **Offer something specific**, such as a walk, a meal, a lift to the doctor or an evening sitting together. A small, practical offer is

easier to accept than a big, vague one.

- **Ask directly about safety if you're worried.** "Are you having thoughts of ending your life?" If yes, stay with them, and get help together today.
- **Look after yourself too.** Supporting someone who is struggling is tiring. See Book 3, Chapter 7 (page 119).

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm not trying to fix it. I just want you to know I'm here."
"Would it help if I came with you to the doctor?"

When to get more help

Talk to a doctor, a counsellor or a mental health service if:

- you've felt low, empty or hopeless, or lost interest in things, most days for two weeks or more;
- worry or panic is stopping you doing things, or you're avoiding more and more;
- something frightening happened over a month ago and still shapes your days and nights;
- you're using alcohol, drugs, food or anything else to cope;
- you're not sleeping, eating or looking after yourself;
- you have thoughts of harming yourself.

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or you are in danger, get help now. Call your local emergency number (911 in the US and Canada, 999 in the UK, 112 in most of Europe). In the US, call or text 988, the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, or text HOME to 741741. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123, or text SHOUT to 85258.

In Canada, call or text 988. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Under 19 in the UK? Childline is free on 0800 1111. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines in your country. More are on Someone to talk to, free.

In England you can usually refer yourself to NHS Talking Therapies without seeing a GP first. Find a counsellor or therapist has more places to start. If someone at home is hurting or frightening you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education. It isn't a diagnosis or a substitute for care from a professional.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Someone to talk to, free · Find a counsellor or therapist
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.
- My weather today: a quick daily check-in on stress, sleep and people.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now



ONLINE
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

More for your situation

- On your own · Grief and later life
- For teens · For parents · New parents
- Caring for someone you love
- At work
- Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)
- **Related chapters:** Stress (Chapter 1, page 9) · Self-worth and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 81) · Healing (Chapter 5, page 89)

- Help by relationship: find the pages for your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On your own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
For parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/parents



ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system page 9
The stress ladder and rest

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion Know Yourself Kindly, page 81
A kinder inner voice

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well Understanding Each Other, page 119
Supporting someone who is struggling

Book 1, Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words Know Yourself Kindly, page 25
Checking your weather each day

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for hard moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
Steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-16-worry-in-depth

4

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 4

Loss, grief and big life changes

What grief is, why it comes in waves, how it shows up in the body, and how to carry a loss, or a big change, without having to "get over it."

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Grief is love with nowhere to go
2. Grief comes in waves, not neat stages
3. Grief lives in the body, too
4. Some losses nobody sees
5. People grieve in different ways
6. You don't have to let go
7. Big changes are losses too, even the good ones
8. Most people find a way through, and support helps
9. Losing a partner in later life
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Grief is love with nowhere to go.** It hurts because the person, place or life mattered.
- **It comes in waves.** A good week followed by a bad day is part of grieving, and it doesn't send you back to the start.
- **You don't have to let go.** Many people keep a bond with the person they lost, and that is healthy.
- **Most people find a way through.** Support helps, and some losses need more help than friends can give.

SATURDAY, 9:05AM

Six months on, you are doing fine, or so you tell people. Then in the supermarket you see the cereal your dad always bought, the one with the faded blue box, and you have to leave your trolley in the aisle and go and sit in the car. Nobody around you knows why.

This chapter is for anyone who has lost someone or something, whether a person, a pet, a marriage, a friendship, their health, a home, a job, a country or a future they had pictured. It looks at how grief works and then at what can help. There is no right way to grieve, and nothing here is a timetable.

01

Grief is love with nowhere to go.

Grief is what we feel when something we were attached to is gone, and it isn't only for deaths. A divorce, a miscarriage, a diagnosis, a move, a friend who drifted away or children leaving home can all bring real grief. Its size usually matches the size of the bond, whatever other people think the loss ought to mean. A man may be surprised by how hard he takes his dog's death while his friends tell him it was only a dog, yet that dog walked beside him every morning for twelve years, through two jobs and a divorce.

It can help to say a loss out loud to yourself, especially one you have never called grief. "I'm grieving the friendship" or "I'm grieving the life we planned" is a small sentence that often brings some relief, because it gives the feeling a name and a reason.

02

Grief comes in waves, not neat stages.

You may have heard of five stages of grief, running from denial through anger, bargaining and depression to acceptance. They came from listening to people who were dying, and they were never meant as steps that everyone follows in order. Most people swing back and forth, spending some hours deep in the loss and some hours getting on with life, and that swing is healthy. A widow may feel guilty for enjoying lunch with her sister and then cry all evening, and both the lunch and the tears are part of grieving.

Letting yourself have a small break from grief, such as a walk, a programme you like or a meal with a friend, takes nothing away from the person you lost. When a wave comes, it usually passes, even if it knocks you over first.

03

Grief lives in the body, too.

Grief can bring tiredness, poor sleep, no appetite or extra appetite, aches, a tight chest, forgetfulness and a foggy head. Your brain is slowly learning that someone or something it expected to be there has gone, and that learning takes time and uses energy. A teacher whose mother has died keeps losing her keys and forgetting meetings, and she starts to worry that something is wrong with her memory. It is grief fog, and it eases as the months pass, though nobody can tell her exactly when.

While it lasts, protect a few basics, such as one regular meal, a set bedtime and a short walk outside. It is fine to tell people at work or at home, “I’m grieving, so I’m slower than usual. Could you send me a reminder?”

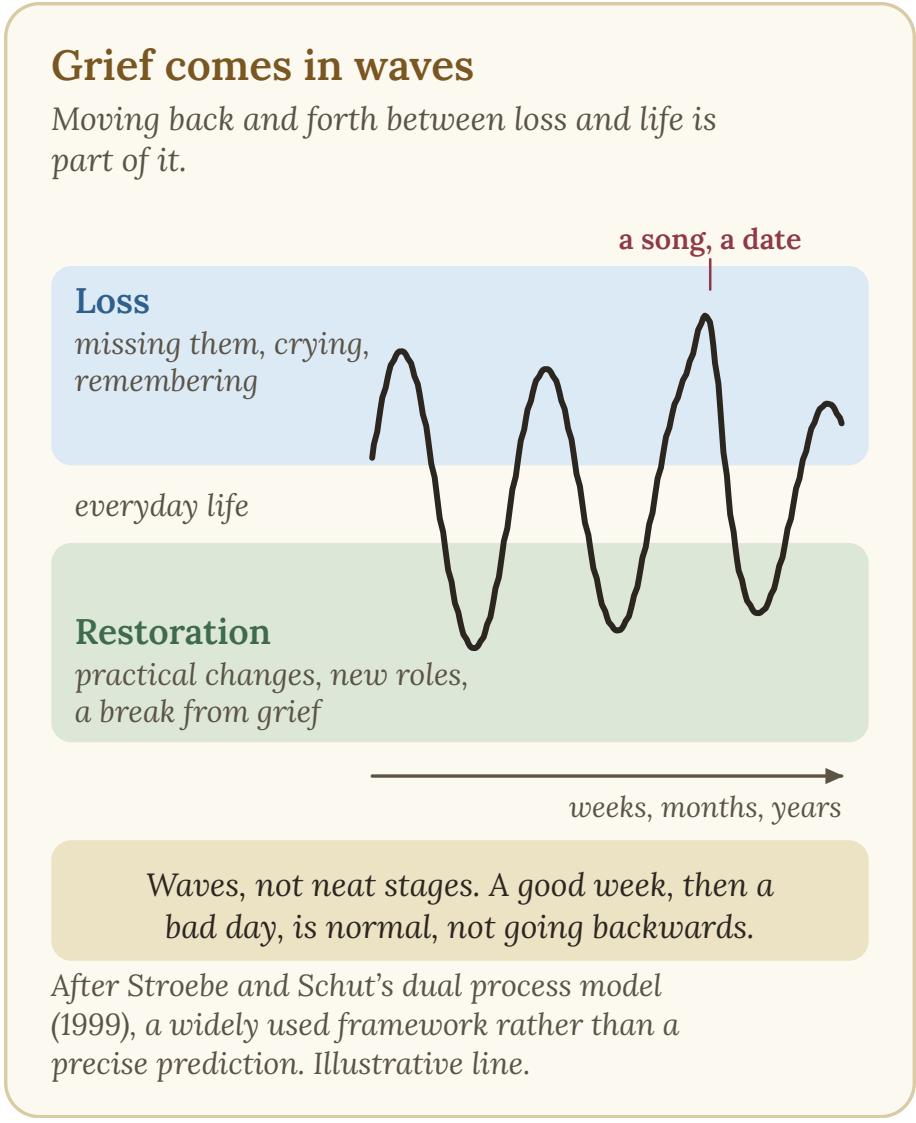


FIGURE 5 Grief comes in waves, not neat stages. Moving back and forth between loss and everyday life is part of healthy grieving.

04

Some losses nobody sees.

Some losses are hard to explain to anyone else. Someone may still be alive but changed, through dementia, addiction or illness, or gone without having died, like an estranged parent or a missing

relative. Other losses go unrecognised, such as the death of an ex-partner, a pregnancy loss or a friend you only ever knew online. A woman whose father has dementia still visits him every Sunday, but the dad who knew her is fading, and she is grieving someone who hasn't died. Grief without a ceremony, or without anyone noticing, can feel very lonely.

If a loss of yours had no ceremony, you can make a small one of your own by lighting a candle, writing a letter, planting something or visiting a place that mattered. You might also tell one person, "I'm grieving something people might not see as a loss. It is one for me."

05

People grieve in different ways.

Some people grieve by talking and crying, and others by doing, whether that means fixing things, organising, working or building something. Neither way is more loving. Families often clash because one person thinks another isn't grieving when they are grieving differently, and culture, faith, age and how your mind works all shape the way it comes out. After their son's death, one parent wants to talk about him every evening while the other spends every weekend in the garage restoring his old bike. Each feels the other is getting it wrong, and each is grieving the same boy.

A question can bridge the gap. "What has helped you most, even a little?" asked of someone who shares your loss, and listened to without correcting, often shows that the two of you want the same thing by different roads.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

Write it through

Edith, 74, seven months after her husband died, writing to her son and daughter

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)
Malcolm and Fiona

Your name (optional)
Mum

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · *Make a plan* · Say sorry · I need a pause

What we need to plan (one thing)
How often we ring and visit. Since your dad died in March, I've had a call every evening at seven and a visit every Sunday.

How I feel about it

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · hurt · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · embarrassed · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · *grateful*

What I suggest (one clear suggestion)
Could we change to a call on Wednesdays and Sundays, and I'll ring you if I need you in between?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)
I'm not pushing you away. I love hearing from you, and I miss your dad too.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Fiona rang the same evening: "Of course. Will you still tell us on a bad day?" Edith said she would.

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

06

You don't have to let go.

An older idea said that healthy grief meant moving on and cutting ties. Many grief researchers now see it differently. People often keep a bond with the person they lost, in memories, rituals, conversations in their head and values they carry forward, so the relationship changes shape without having to end. A teenager wears her grandfather's watch to every exam. She doesn't believe in luck, and she would find it hard to explain why the watch matters, except that it feels as if he is in the room.

You might choose one way of keeping a bond, such as cooking their recipe, telling a story about them at a family meal or keeping

one of their habits. Some people find it helps to ask, in a hard moment, what the person they lost would have said.

07

Big changes are losses too, even the good ones.

A new baby, a promotion, retirement, moving country, a child starting school, coming out or getting well after a long illness can all bring grief for the old life. Change often has three parts, an ending, a confusing time in between and a new beginning, and the middle part is both the hardest and the easiest to rush. A couple moves to a new city for a job they both wanted. Six months in, one of them feels low and then guilty for feeling low, because this was the plan. What they also lost, though, was a circle of friends, a favourite café and a whole way of life.

You can be glad about a change and still miss what came before. For one change you are going through, it may help to write down what ended, what still feels unclear and one small thing that is new and good.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When a change is hard to talk about, writing can come first. This is a quiet place to put the words down, at your own pace, and to send them only if you want to.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/write-it-through

08

Most people find a way through, and support helps.

Research suggests that, over time, many people find they can live with a loss and still feel joy, even though they never forget. Being with people who let you talk, or let you stay quiet, helps. For some people, though, grief stays at full strength for a long time and makes daily life very hard.

Doctors call this **prolonged grief**. It means a strong longing for the person, or being taken over by the loss, most days, still going many months after the death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline) and getting in the way of life. It has nothing to do with weakness, and there is specific help for it. A year after his wife died, a man still can't go into their bedroom or see his friends, and his doctor refers him to a grief counsellor. Things begin to move slowly, starting with one evening a week at his brother's.

On a good day, write down two people you could text on a hard one, and one place you could call if those people aren't enough. If it has been a long time and nothing is easing, it is reasonable to say, "I think I need more help."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control the loss, how long grief lasts, or how other people react to it. You can control small things: eating something, resting, telling one person how you are, and saying no to what you can't manage right now. That is enough for a hard season. More in Book 1, Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

SATURDAY, 9:40AM

You sit in the car for ten minutes and let the wave come. Then you go back in, find your trolley where you left it and put the cereal in. At home you text your sister that you saw Dad's cereal and cried in the car park. She replies straight away that the same thing happened to her with his aftershave in a chemist's, and asks whether you can call tonight.

Losing a partner in later life

After a long marriage the loss is in everything, from the empty chair to the jobs that were always theirs, the paperwork done alone and the first birthday and anniversary without them. Do one small thing at a time, and let one drawer count as a day's work. It is fine to ask someone to sit with you while you fill in the forms.

Your grown-up children have lost a parent while you have lost a partner, and you may grieve on different timetables. If they start checking on you every day, that comes from love and worry, not control. You can still say what helps: "I love that you ring. Could we make it two evenings a week, and I'll ring you if I need you?"

In everyday life

After a miscarriage, one partner may want to talk while the other goes quiet, and each can end up worrying that the other doesn't care. A child may laugh and play the day after a funeral and then cry at bedtime, and both belong to grief. A friend who stops calling after your diagnosis is often stuck for words more than cold, and colleagues who avoid the subject when someone returns after a death can leave that person feeling as if the loss has been erased. A

whole community can grieve together too, when a town loses its library or its factory.

On your own: carrying it gently

Grief can be lonely even with people around you. When you are carrying it alone, it helps to give the day a small shape, with one meal, one walk and one person you message. Expect harder days around birthdays and anniversaries, and plan something gentle for them. Writing to the person you lost, or about what you lost, can help too, and nobody else ever needs to read it. Some days the only goal is to get to tonight, and that is allowed.

IF SOMEONE CLOSE TO YOU HAS DIED. Grief and later life goes further, with family after a loss, coming back to people, and a new chapter on your own. On a heavy night, the page called For a hard evening may help.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Grief and later life · For a hard evening
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Show up, and keep showing up.** Support often floods in for two weeks and then stops, so a text at three months, or on a birthday, can mean a great deal.

- **Offer something specific.** "Can I drop off dinner on Thursday?" is easier to say yes to than "Let me know if you need anything."
- **Say the name.** Many grieving people find it a comfort to hear the name of the person they lost, and to hear a memory of them. If you are unsure, ask.
- **Leave out the explanations.** "Everything happens for a reason" and "At least…" tend to hurt, while "I'm so sorry. I'm here" rarely does.
- **Comfort in, vent out.** If you are upset too, lean on people further from the loss rather than on those closest to it.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." "I was thinking about your mum today. I remember her laugh." "I'm going to the shop. What can I bring you?"

When to get more help

Grief is not an illness. But it's worth talking to a doctor or a grief counsellor if, after many months, the pain isn't easing at all, you can't manage daily life, you feel life has no meaning without the person, or you are drinking or using other things to get through. Many hospices, faith communities and charities offer free bereavement support, including for children.

If you are having thoughts of not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If a loss involved violence, or you are grieving a relationship you left because you weren't safe, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has free, private help, including after you separate (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#after-separation).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home? · after you separate
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for a wave that feels too big

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

More for your situation

- **After a breakup or divorce:** On my own
- **Families after a loss:** Grief and family · Family rifts after a loss or a will

- **Children and teens:** Helping children grieve · For teens
- **Big changes:** Empty nest · Retired together · Coming home after time apart · New parent
- **Illness and caring:** When one of you is ill · Caring for someone you love
- **Friendships:** When a friendship drifts
- **Related chapters:** Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (Book 1, Chapter 5, page 81) · Minds that work differently (Book 1, Chapter 7, page 117)

Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



ONLINE
Grief and family · Helping children grieve
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
Family rifts after a loss or a will
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens



ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest



ONLINE
Retired together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/retired-together



ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home



ONLINE
New parent
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent



ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance.com/when-one-is-ill



ONLINE
Caring for someone you love
spreadloveandacceptance.com/caregivers



ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging — Understanding Each Other, page 63
Why losing a bond hurts so much

Book 3, Chapter 7 · Helping others well — Understanding Each Other, page 119
Supporting someone who is grieving

Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma — page 51
When grief turns into low mood

Book 1, Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from — Know Yourself Kindly, page 9
Losses that shaped your lens

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For a wave that feels too big
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music
For a quiet few minutes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-8-loss-in-depth

5

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 5

Healing after hurt: repair, forgiveness, and when to get help

How hurt heals, why it lingers, how small breaks get mended, what a real apology sounds like, what forgiveness is and isn't, and when it's time to get more help.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Hurt is real, and healing takes time
2. Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts
3. Telling someone they hurt you
4. A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it
5. Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back
6. You can heal even if they never say sorry
7. Trust comes back in small, kept promises
8. Going back is a choice. Safety comes first
9. Look after the hurt part of you
10. In everyday life
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Hurt is real, and healing takes time.** Replaying a hurt says more about how much it mattered than about any weakness in you.
- **Repair is what counts.** Every close relationship has breaks, and a real apology names what happened, owns it and offers to mend it.

- **Forgiving and going back are separate choices.** You can forgive without forgetting, excusing or letting someone back in.
- **Safety comes first.** You can heal even if they never say sorry, and you never owe anyone a risk to your safety.

THURSDAY, 2AM

It was one sentence, three weeks ago, and they have probably forgotten it. You haven't. It plays again word for word, along with all the things you could have said back, and you are tired of carrying it without knowing how to put it down.

Everyone gets hurt, and everyone hurts other people, mostly without meaning to. This chapter looks at how hurt works, how relationships mend and how you can heal, with or without the other person, for small hurts and bigger ones. If someone is hurting you on purpose, or you feel afraid, start with safety first: Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

01

Hurt is real, and healing takes time.

Being hurt by someone shows that something mattered, whether the person, your trust or your sense of being respected. The mind replays hurts because it is trying to understand them and keep you

safe. Healing rarely runs in a straight line, and the feeling can come back on an anniversary or when something reminds you, without meaning you have failed.

Months after a friend said something cruel at a party, Kwesi feels a jolt when the song that was playing comes on the radio. He tells himself it is an old bruise being pressed, and turns the volume down.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"This hurts because it mattered." "A feeling coming back doesn't mean I'm back at the start."

TRY THIS.

When a hurt replays, notice it, name it ("there's that memory again"), and gently bring your attention to something in the room you can see or touch.

02

Every close relationship has breaks. Repair is what counts.

No relationship is smooth all the time, and people snap, forget, misread and let each other down. Research on parents and babies, on couples and on therapy points the same way. Breaks are normal, and what matters most is whether they get mended. A small repair, made soon, often leaves a relationship feeling safer than before.

For example, a dad snaps at his son for spilling juice. Twenty minutes later he sits down next to him and says, "I was grumpy and I shouted. That wasn't fair. Spills happen. Want to help me make a new one?"

YOU COULD SAY

"Can I have a do-over? That came out badly." "I didn't like how I spoke to you earlier. I'm sorry."

THIS WEEK.

Think of a small break this week, with anyone. Go back and repair it with one sentence.

03

Telling someone they hurt you.

People can't mend what they don't know about. Saying "that hurt" is a risk, but it gives the relationship a chance, and it works best when you describe what happened and how it felt, leaving out what kind of person they are. Pick a calm moment, well away from the middle of an argument.

Amara says to her friend, "When you told the group about my breakup before I was ready, I felt exposed. I'd like to be the one who shares my news." She leaves the word "gossip" out of it entirely and sticks to what happened and what she needs.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

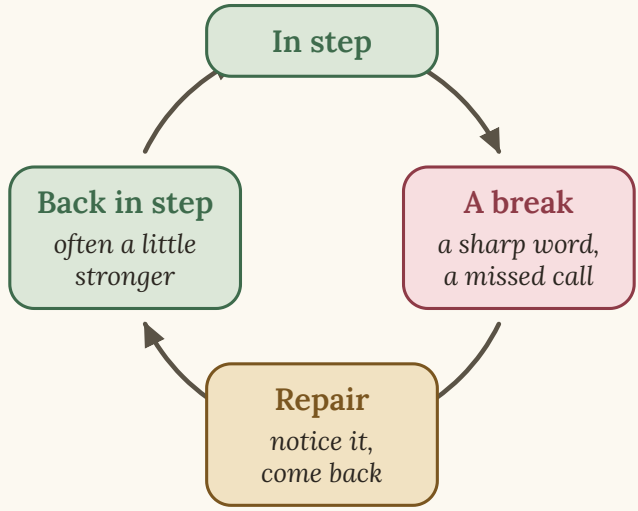
"When… happened, I felt… What I'd like is…" "I'm telling you because I want us to be okay."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Before you say it, write it in three short lines, covering what happened, how you felt and what you would like.

Every close relationship has breaks

What counts is coming back.



A real apology

Name it	Own it	Mend it
say what you did	*no "but"*	*now and next time*

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

Everyday breaks and repairs show up in parent and baby play (Tronick), in couples (Gottman's "repair attempts") and in therapy (Eubanks and colleagues, 2018).

FIGURE 6 Every close relationship has breaks; what counts is the repair. A real apology names it, owns it and mends it.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

Write it through

Carys, writing to her brother Owen

Write it, wait, then send

Who is it to?

Partner · Co-parent or ex · *Family* · Friend · Housemate · Coworker · More than one person · Someone else

Their name (optional)

Owen

Your name (optional)

Carys

What kind of message?

Raise something · Reply to something · Make a plan · Say sorry · I need a pause

What happened (facts only, one thing)

At Dad's 70th on Saturday, you said to everyone at the table that I don't visit. I visited three times in September.

How it landed for me

tired · rushed · frustrated · unseen · taken for granted · overwhelmed · stretched thin · worried · *hurt* · disappointed · left out · alone with it · confused · *embarrassed* · annoyed · sad · on edge · hopeful · grateful

What I'm asking for (one clear ask)

Could we talk on the phone this week about how we share the visits?

What I'm NOT saying (optional, but it helps)

I'm not angry with you as a person.

When I'd like a reply

Today · Tomorrow · *By the weekend* · No rush

A GENTLE CHECK

House rules: ✓ One topic · ✓ Facts, not verdicts · ✓ No always or never · ✓ No sarcasm or ALL CAPS · ✓ No "you" accusations · ✓ Says what you're asking for · ✓ A reply-by time

No sharp words found. It reads as calm and clear.

Then the tool asks her to wait before she sends it.

Fill in your own: Write it through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL

Write it through

spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

04

A real apology names it, owns it, and mends it.

"Sorry if you were upset" doesn't heal much. A real apology says what you did, takes responsibility without excuses, shows you understand how it affected the other person, and offers to put it right or do things differently. Research, such as a study led by Roy Lewicki (2016), suggests owning it and offering repair are the parts that matter most.

For example, Leila presented a shared idea in a meeting as if it were hers. The next day she tells her colleague, "I presented our idea as mine. That wasn't fair to you. I'll email the team today and say it was joint work."

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I did… That was my doing. I can see it left you feeling… Here's what I'll do."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Next time you say sorry, check it covers what you did, that it was yours, how it affected them and what you will do now. Apology languages has more.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

An apology lands best when it's plain: what happened, that it was yours, and what you'll do now. Rewind the talk can help you find those words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Apology languages
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

05

Forgiveness isn't forgetting, excusing or going back.

Forgiveness is usually described as letting go of resentment and the wish to get even, and it happens inside you. Forgiving someone doesn't mean saying that what happened was okay, or forgetting it, or trusting the person again, or keeping them in your life. It is a choice, often a slow one, and you never owe it on someone else's timetable.

Danielle forgave her father for missing much of her childhood. She still keeps his visits short, and she still won't leave her children alone with him when he has been drinking, and for her the forgiving and the protecting sit together without strain.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I can let go of wanting to get even, and still keep my limits." "I don't have to forgive today. I can just stop feeding the anger today."

TRY THIS.

Write down what forgiving someone would mean to you, and what it would not mean. Seeing the difference can make it feel possible, or show you that you aren't ready, which is fine too.

06

You can heal even if they never say sorry.

Waiting for an apology that never comes can keep you stuck, because the person may be gone, unwilling or unable to understand. Your healing doesn't have to depend on them. You can make sense of what happened, tell your story to someone safe and decide what it means for you now.

After a hard breakup, Martha writes a letter she never sends, covering what hurt, what she had hoped for and what she is taking with her. She folds it into the back of a notebook, and over the following weeks she finds she reaches for it less often.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I don't need them to understand for my healing to count."

THIS WEEK.

Write about the hurt for fifteen minutes, three or four days in a row. Write about the facts and your feelings. If it ever makes you feel much worse, stop, and talk to someone instead.

07

Trust comes back in small, kept promises.

After trust is broken, one big apology rarely rebuilds it. Trust grows back slowly, in many small moments where someone does what they said they would do. If you broke trust, being patient and consistent matters more than a grand gesture, and if you were let down, it is fair to watch what someone does as well as what they say.

For example, Declan hid a credit card debt from his partner. After it came out, he offered to share his bank statements each month, without being asked. After a year of small, steady openness, his partner says she can breathe again.

WORDS TO TRY

"I know my words aren't enough. I want to show you, over time." "I need to see it for a while before I can feel it."

ONE SMALL STEP.

If you're rebuilding trust, choose one small promise you can keep every week, and keep it.

08

Going back is a choice. Safety comes first.

After a hurt, you can mend the relationship, change its shape, or step away. All three can be healthy. If someone keeps hurting you after you've told them, if you feel afraid of them, or if they control, threaten or put you down, the work is to protect yourself, not to

repair. Counselling together isn't advised when someone is afraid of their partner.

Ellie's housemate borrowed money twice and didn't pay it back. Ellie let the first time go. The second time she said, "I won't lend money again. I still want us to get on in the house," and they still share the Sunday roast most weeks.

YOU COULD SAY

"I'm not angry any more, and I'm not going back to how it was."
"I need some distance while I work out what I want."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Ask yourself whether it is safe, whether the hurt has stopped and whether you want this relationship in your life, and let the answers guide what comes next. If you feel unsafe, see signs to look out for (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#signs).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

09

Look after the hurt part of you.

Hurt lives in the body as well as the mind, as poor sleep, a tight chest or a jumpy feeling. Healing goes better with basic care, which means rest, food, movement, people who are kind to you, and talking to yourself the way you would talk to a hurting friend.

Some people find they grow after something painful, and some don't, and neither is a test.

A man shouted at Idris on the bus and called him names. For days afterwards he felt shaky. He told a friend, went for long walks and kept reminding himself that it was about the man on the bus and that he was safe now, and over a couple of weeks the shakiness faded.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This was hard. Anyone would be shaken. What do I need right now?"

TRY THIS.

Pick one small act of care for today, perhaps an early night or a call to someone kind. Calm tools are in Upset right now?

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.
com/upset-right-now

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can say what hurt, apologise for what you did, and look after your own healing. You can't make someone apologise, understand or change, and you don't have to wait for them to start feeling better. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time.

SATURDAY, 11AM

You have written it all down, every word of it, and then a smaller version. "When you said that, I felt small. I'd like you to know." You still haven't decided whether to send it, and it sits in your drafts. The two o'clock replays have gone a little quieter since it went onto paper.

ANOTHER WAY TO SEE IT

Fine all day, falling apart at home

FROM OUTSIDE At work or school they're fine. At home they melt down or go silent.

THE LOGIC Fitting in all day takes effort that doesn't show → The effort is held in until it is safe to stop → Home feels safe, so the holding lets go → The crash shows that home is trusted

IT'S LIKE Holding your breath underwater and gasping at the surface.

WHY IT FITS Autistic adults describe "camouflaging" followed by exhaustion, and many other people do a version of it too.

THE OTHER SIDE The family gets the hardest part of the day.

YOU COULD SAY *"I hold it together all day. Home is where I can stop."*

ONE SMALL STEP A quiet half hour after getting home, with no questions. Later, a line like "That wasn't about you" helps.

More situations like this one, each in the same six parts, are free online.
spreadloveandacceptance.com/the-logic-behind-it?item=mask-crash

In everyday life

Between partners, small breaks happen most days, and a quick "That came out wrong. Can I try again?" mends most of them (see How to apologise so it counts). Old family hurts often need a different kind of talk from new ones, and sometimes more time apart. A friend may not know they hurt you, and "Can I tell you something that stung? I'd rather say it than drift" keeps the door

open. You can even heal a hurt with someone who has died, by writing to them or talking it through with someone you trust.

- **After an affair.** The shock is real for both people. Couples can recover, and some decide to part; both can be done with care. Trust returns through kept promises over months, and a couples therapist can help. More in the full chapter.
- **If you decide to separate.** Part as kindly as you can. Tell children together, without blame, and never ask them to choose. Write decisions down, and consider family mediation where it's safe. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
How to apologise so it counts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Listen before you advise.** "That sounds really painful" helps more than "You should just let it go."
- **Don't rush forgiveness.** Pushing someone to forgive can feel like being told their hurt doesn't matter.
- **Don't push them to cut someone off, either.** It's their relationship and their choice, unless they're in danger.
- **If you caused the hurt,** give a real apology and then give them time. Don't ask them to make you feel better about it.
- **If they mention fear, threats or control,** take it seriously and share Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Do you want to talk it through, or would it help more to take your mind off it?" "Whatever you decide about them, I'm on your side."

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

When to get more help

Some hurts are too heavy to carry alone, and getting help is a sign of strength, not weakness. Think about talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if:

- More than a month after something frightening, you still have flashbacks, nightmares, feel constantly on edge, or avoid places and people that remind you of it. These can be signs of trauma, and there are well-tested treatments for it, such as trauma-focused talking therapies.
- The hurt is taking over: you can't sleep, work or enjoy anything, or you're drinking or using more to cope.
- The hurt came from abuse or violence, now or in the past. The page Free, private people to talk to (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety#talk) includes specialist lines.
- You're having thoughts of hurting yourself or someone else. Please reach out today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In

Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If anyone is in danger now, call your local emergency number.

If you and someone else both want to mend things, a couples or family counsellor can help, as long as nobody is afraid of the other.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Free, private people to talk to
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? for calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

TOOL
My weather today: the sky (the ladder)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

More for your situation

- **Families:** Adult siblings and family rifts · For grown-up children
- **After a breakup:** On my own · Co-parenting

- **Friends:** When a friendship drifts
- **Children who have been hurt:** Foster, adoptive and kinship families
- **After a loss:** Grief and later life
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter is for everyday hurts and for thinking about bigger ones. It isn't therapy, and it isn't a reason to stay somewhere unsafe. If you're afraid of someone, the most healing step is getting safe. Not safe at home?
(spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety)

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Adult siblings and family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts



ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



ONLINE
When a friendship drifts
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Foster, adoptive and kinship families
spreadloveandacceptance.com/foster-and-kinship



ONLINE
Grief and later life
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief



ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
Covering kindly and saying it out loud
Share the Load, page 71

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works
Repair in everyday talk
Understanding Each Other, page 27

Chapter 2 · Anger
When anger did the damage
page 31

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Guilt without shame
Know Yourself Kindly, page 81

PUT IT TO USE

Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
For calming down in the moment, and the Nervous System Ladder for checking your state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Apology languages
How to say sorry so it lands, and asking for forgiveness
spreadloveandacceptance.com/apology-languages

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-11-healing-in-depth

6

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 6

Habits and change: why change is hard and how small steps work

Why it's so hard to change, even when we really want to, and what actually helps: small steps, a kinder setup, patience with slips, and remembering that other people's change belongs to them.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Change is hard for good reasons
2. Habits run on cues
3. Start smaller than feels useful
4. Change the setup, not just your willpower
5. Being in two minds is normal
6. Slips are part of change
7. Change sticks when it fits who you want to be
8. You can support change, but not force it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Three tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **One small step a week** (the six-week program; Book 1, Chapter 3 (page 45)) works because change that lasts starts smaller than feels useful, and an if-then plan does the deciding ahead of time.
- **The setup score and One owner per job** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) change the setup instead of asking for more willpower, because habits follow cues and easy paths.

- **What keeps coming back?** (Book 4, Chapter 5 (page 93)) treats a repeat as information about the plan, because slips are a normal part of change.

MONDAY, 7:05AM

The plan was a walk before work, and the trainers are by the door. Somehow the phone is in your hand instead, and at 7:40 you are still scrolling beside a cup of cold coffee. By evening a quiet voice is telling you that you never stick to anything, though what you actually ran into this morning was a habit with years of practice behind it.

01

Change is hard for good reasons.

Much of what we do each day runs on autopilot, which saves energy and is the reason habits exist at all. The downside is that the old way is always quicker and easier than the new one, so change asks your brain to do something effortful again and again until the new way becomes the easy one.

For example, Jodie wants to stop snapping at her children in the morning rush, and she means it every night. Every morning the same rush brings the same snap, somewhere between the lost reading book and the cold toast, because the morning has worn a groove deeper than her good intentions.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This is hard because it's a habit." "Old grooves take time to fill in."

TRY THIS.

Pick one thing you would like to change and write down when it usually happens, where, and what is going on just before.

02

Habits run on cues.

Most habits have a trigger, such as a time, a place, a feeling, a person or the thing you have just done. The cue starts the routine, and some kind of reward, like relief, comfort or a little buzz, keeps it going. Once you know the cue, you can plan for it.

A man notices that he reaches for snacks when he opens his laptop after dinner, whether he is hungry or not. Since the laptop is the cue, he starts making a pot of tea before he opens it.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

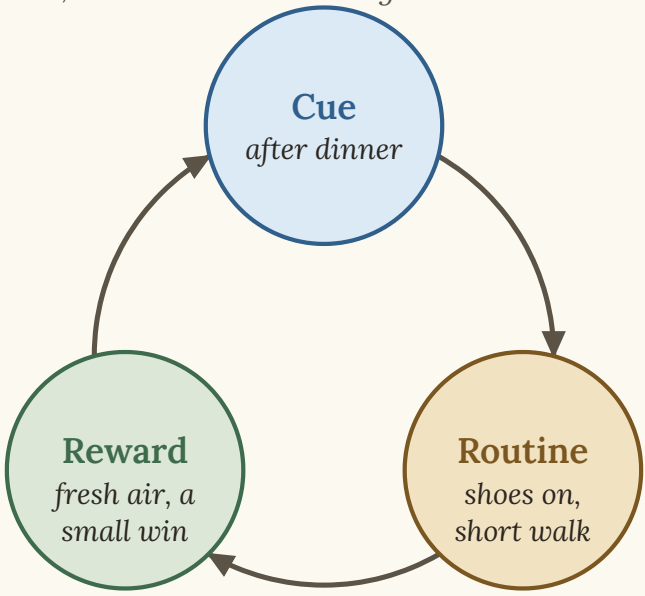
"What happened right before I did that?" "What was I getting from it?"

THIS WEEK.

For three days, each time the habit happens, jot down the time, the place, the feeling and what you were doing just before.

Habits run on cues

Over time, the cue alone is enough.



Change the setup, not just your willpower: *move the cue, make the step tiny.*

The cue, routine and reward loop is a popular simplification; the core idea, that context triggers habits, is well supported (for example Neal, Wood and colleagues, 2011).

FIGURE 7 Habits run on cues. Over time the cue alone is enough, so change the setup, not just your willpower.

03

Start smaller than feels useful.

Big goals are inspiring but easy to drop. Tiny steps feel almost silly, and they work because they are easy enough to do on a bad day. It helps to tie the new step to something you already do, as in "After I put the kettle on, I'll…", and to grow it only once it has stuck.

For example, two housemates want a tidier kitchen. They have been promising each other a big weekly clean for months, so they agree instead that after dinner each of them wipes one surface. It takes two minutes, and by the second week the hob has stopped being a source of tension.

YOU COULD SAY

"Let's start with something tiny, and see if it sticks." "After I …, I will …"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Shrink your change until it takes two minutes or less. Write it as "After I ___, I will ___."

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

Your done list

Bernie, 71, living on his own

Your done list

Write down one small thing that went right, however small.

A small win

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe

Who it was with

With a friend

THIS WEEK: 4 SMALL WINS

Went to the Thursday quiz with Rita and Joe · Thu, Oct 8 · With a friend

Cleared one shelf in the spare room · Wed, Oct 7

Rang my brother back · Tue, Oct 6 · With family

Walked to the post office instead of driving · Mon, Oct 5

A done list is for encouragement, not proving who does more.

Fill in your own: Your done list

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE

Your done list

spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

04

Change the setup, not just your willpower.

Willpower runs low when we are tired, hungry or stressed, while your surroundings stay the same all day. Make the new habit easier by putting it in sight or getting things ready the night before, and make the old one a little harder by moving it out of reach or adding a step. Small changes to your setup often do more than trying harder.

A teenager wants to sleep better and has tried for weeks to stop scrolling in bed. Then he starts charging his phone in the kitchen overnight, and within a week he is asleep before midnight most nights.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

(to yourself or a partner) “What could we change about the setup so this gets easier?”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Make one small change to your space today that makes the new habit easier or the old one harder.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Changing the setup is often easier than changing a person. At home, that can be as simple as one owner for each job.

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-03 · free to print
One owner per job
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-03

05

Being in two minds is normal.

Part of you wants to change and part of you doesn’t, and the reluctant part usually has its reasons. The old habit may give comfort, save effort or protect you from something. Pushing harder against that part rarely works, while listening to it often does.

For example, Asif wants to drink less, but he also loves Friday evenings in the pub with his team. When he asks himself what Friday gives him, the answer is friends, laughter and a way to

unwind, so he keeps the Friday and switches to alcohol-free after the first pint.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What does the old habit give me?" "What would make the change worth it to me?"

TRY THIS.

Write two lists, one of what you like about how things are and one of what you would like about changing. Both lists are allowed.

06

Slips are part of change.

Nearly everyone who changes something slips back sometimes, and one slip doesn't undo your progress. What often does the damage is the thought that follows, the "I've blown it, so why bother?" Treating yourself kindly after a slip makes it more likely that you will start again.

After three calm weeks, a dad shouts at his son over homework. That night he sits on the end of the bed and says, "I shouted, and I'm sorry. I'm working on it." The next evening they do the homework at the kitchen table with the radio on, and nobody raises their voice.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"A slip is one moment out of many." "What made today harder, and what can I plan for next time?"

THIS WEEK.

Decide now what you will do after a slip, such as one kind sentence to yourself and one small step to start again.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: a slip is a stumble, not a fall. Shake it off and try the tiny step again tomorrow. A game for small kind acts makes practising more fun!

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

07

Change sticks when it fits who you want to be.

Change made only to please others, or out of shame, is hard to keep. Change that connects to what you care about, to the kind of person, parent, friend or colleague you want to be, has deeper roots, and each small action becomes a vote for that person.

For example, a woman who keeps meaning to be better at keeping in touch starts thinking of herself as someone who shows up for her friends. Sending one voice note on a Sunday evening becomes part of who she is, and some weeks it turns into an hour on the phone.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> “Who am I becoming with this step?” “This matters to me because…”

ONE SMALL STEP.

Finish this sentence for your change: “I want to do this because I care about...”

08

You can support change, but not force it.

It is natural to want the people we love to change, perhaps to drink less, tidy more or look after themselves better. Their change belongs to them, though, and pressure tends to make people dig in. It helps more to say clearly what you need, to ask what would help and to notice their small steps out loud.

A coworker keeps missing deadlines. His teammate skips the lecture about being organised and asks what would make the handover easier, and the two of them set up a shared checklist that he now updates every Friday.

WAYS TO SAY IT

“I can’t change this for you, but I’d love to help if you want me to.” “I noticed you did that this week. That really helped.”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Notice one small positive change someone else made this week, and tell them.

TWO WEEKS LATER, 7:05AM

The trainers are still by the door, but the phone charges in the kitchen overnight now, and the plan has shrunk to shoes on and out to the end of the road. Some mornings that is all you manage. Most mornings it turns into a walk past the allotments and back. On the Thursday you miss, the voice starts up again, and you tell it that tomorrow you will get as far as the end of the road.

In everyday life

Take one couple who want to spend less time on their phones in the evening. Earlier attempts failed because each of them watched the other, so this time they agree on a basket by the door where both phones go at nine, with one exception for whoever is on call for an elderly parent. The first week is awkward, and on the Wednesday one of them sneaks a look at the football scores. By the third week the basket has become part of the furniture, and the evenings have a shape again, with a film, a crossword or an early night.

Big life changes, such as a move, a new baby or a new job, break old routines, which is disruptive and also a good moment to start new habits. If you have ADHD, make the cue impossible to miss, do the step the moment it appears and make the reward come straight away. Expect the novelty to wear off, and swap the method when it does instead of blaming yourself. More in the full chapter.

On your own: a kind plan for change

If you are working on something alone, the ideas fit into one small plan. Choose one change, the one that would make the most

difference or the one that feels most doable. Give it one cue, written as "After I ___, I will ___." Make one tweak to your setup so it is easier to start, decide on the smallest version you could still do on a tired day, and write down one kind sentence to use after a slip. The self path and Know yourself, next (Book 1, Chapter 3, page 45) walk through this step by step.

SCAN TO OPEN

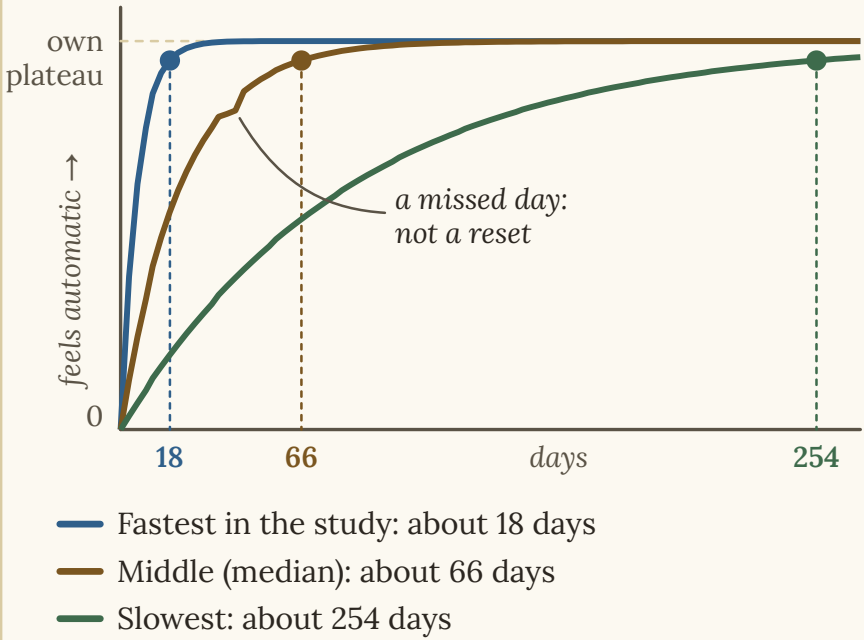
ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

- **"If I really wanted it, I'd just do it."** Wanting is only the start, and habits, setup, tiredness and stress all play a part.
- **"It takes 21 days to form a habit."** There's no magic number. In one study, led by Phillippa Lally (2010), it took about two months on average, with a very wide range.
- **"Being hard on myself will keep me on track."** Harshness tends to make people give up, while kindness makes it easier to try again.
- **"Routines mean being rigid."** For many people, especially autistic people, routines are what make life manageable. Change can respect that.

About two months, give or take a lot

How automatic a new daily habit feels, over time.



Illustrative shapes, not the raw data. Lally and colleagues (2010) followed 96 volunteers; reaching 95% of each person's own plateau took 18 to 254 days, median 66. Simpler habits formed faster.

FIGURE 8 How long a new habit takes to feel automatic: about two months on average, with a very wide range. Illustrative shapes based on Lally and colleagues (2010).

If you want to help someone else with this

Ask before you advise, perhaps with "Would ideas help, or would you rather just talk it through?", and help them find their own

reasons by asking what would be different for them if this changed. Practical help with the setup, such as a lift to the gym, a shared calendar or a quieter evening, often does more than encouragement alone. Notice small steps out loud, be kind about slips, and look after yourself as well, because you can care deeply and still set limits on what you will put up with.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I'm on your side with this. What would help?" "You've done this three days running. That's not nothing."

When to get more help

- **If a habit is harming your health or life,** such as drinking, drugs, gambling, eating or self-harm, please talk to a doctor or a specialist service. Needing help with this is common and nothing to be ashamed of.
- **If you can't stop even though you've tried many times,** professional support can make a real difference. It isn't a sign of weakness.
- **If change feels impossible because you're exhausted or low most days,** that may be burnout or depression. A doctor or counsellor can help.
- **If someone is demanding you change in ways that frighten you,** or punishing you when you don't, that isn't support. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.
- **If you're overwhelmed right now,** start with Upset right now.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TOOL
Cool-down corner: Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Pick one tiny change and try it for a week. The 90-second daily check-in, the quick checks and the self path can help you keep track.

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-13 · free to print
The 90-second daily check-in
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-13

ONLINE
quick checks
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

ONLINE
the self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

More for your situation

- On my own
- New parents
- When a child has ADHD
- Neurodivergent relationships
- Gaming, phones and time together
- At work

- Coming home after time apart
- Find it by relationship

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
New parents
spreadloveandacceptance.com/new-parent

ONLINE
When a child has ADHD
spreadloveandacceptance.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Gaming, phones and time together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/gaming-and-time-together

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
Coming home after time apart
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-home

ONLINE
Find it by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Change is hard for good reasons.** Habits save effort, so the old way is always the easy way.
- ✓ **A small step and a kind setup outlast willpower.** Make the first step tiny and change what is around you.
- ✓ **Slips are part of change.** A missed day tells you something about the plan and nothing about your character.
- ✓ **Other people's change is theirs.** You can support it, though you can't force it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming — Know Yourself Kindly, page 45
One small goal and tiny steps

Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load, page 93
The monthly look-back

Book 4, Chapter 2 · Is the split working? — Share the Load, page 27
Changing the setup, not the person

Book 1, Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change — Know Yourself Kindly, page 97
How much people really change

PUT IT TO USE



Complacency
Why good habits fade, and how to keep them alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/complacency



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-6-change-in-depth

7

BOOK 2 · CHAPTER 7

Values, meaning and a good life: what philosophy offers everyday life

What matters to you, how to find it, what to do when two good things pull against each other, and what a few very old ideas can offer an ordinary, busy week.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Values are directions, not finish lines
2. Your strong feelings point to what you value
3. Two good things can pull in different directions
4. Put your effort where it can land
5. A good life is more than a good mood
6. Meaning comes from ordinary places
7. Different values aren't wrong values
8. Values live in small, everyday acts
9. In everyday life
10. If you want to help someone else with this
11. When to get more help
12. Tools and reading on this site
13. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Values are directions you keep turning towards.** You never finish being kind, and that is why values still work on days when goals fall apart.
- **Strong feelings point to what you value.** Anger often guards fairness, and hurt often guards closeness.
- **Meaning comes from ordinary places.** People, care and everyday work give most of us most of our meaning.

- **Values live in small acts.** One small thing this week, done because it matters, counts.

SUNDAY, 9PM

The week ahead is full, and none of it feels like yours. You aren't sad exactly. You just can't remember the last time you did something because it mattered to you, rather than because it was next on the list.

This chapter is about values, the things you care about and the direction you want your life to face, and about what makes a life feel worth living. It borrows from psychology and from philosophy, which has been asking how we should live for more than two thousand years. You don't need to have read any of it, and everything here is in plain words.

01

Values are directions, not finish lines.

A goal is something you can tick off, such as running a 5k, painting the hall or passing a test. A value is a direction you keep walking in, such as looking after your health, making your home feel cared for or being a fair friend. Nobody ever finishes being kind, which is exactly why a value still works on a day when a goal falls apart.

Bethan planned to go to the gym three times this week and went once, and on Thursday evening she felt like a failure. When she asked herself what the gym was for, the answer was looking after her body so that she had energy for her children. On Friday she walked for twenty minutes at lunchtime, round the park behind the office, and it counted. If you have a goal that has stalled, try asking "what is this for?" three times in a row, and write down where you end up.

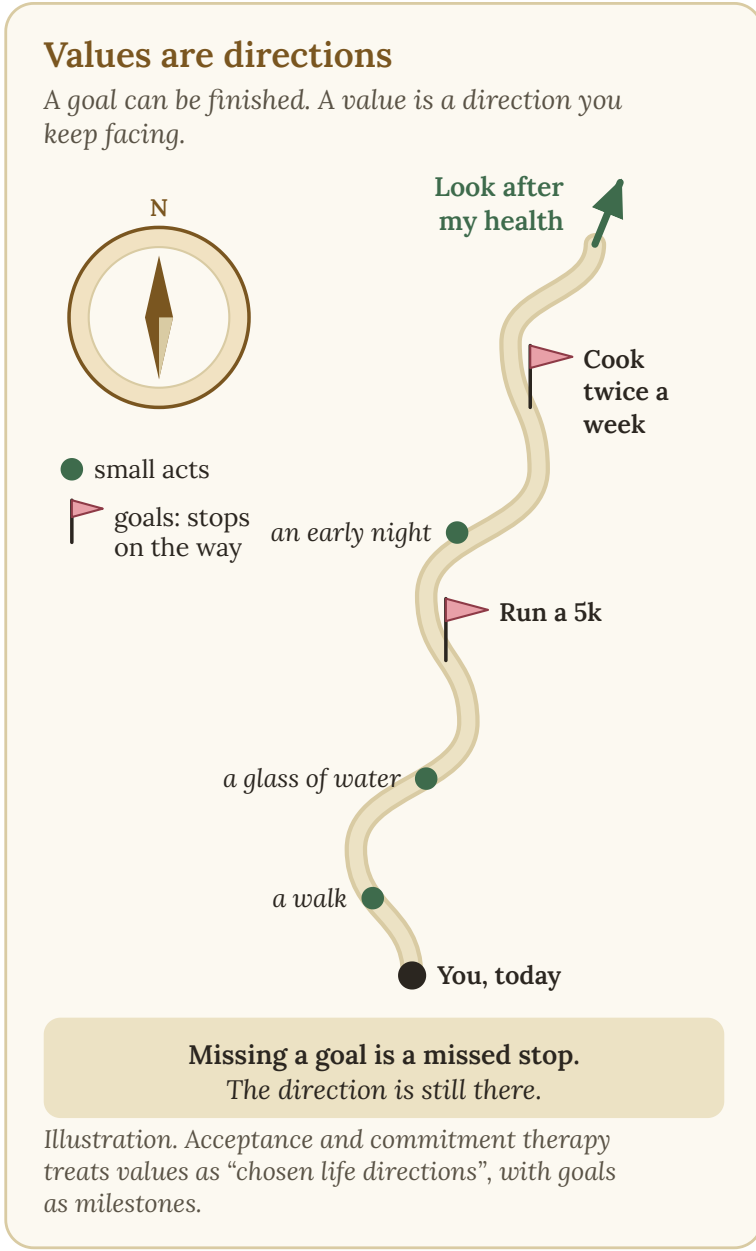


FIGURE 9 Values are directions, not finish lines. Goals are stops on the way; missing one doesn't change the direction.

02

Your strong feelings point to what you value.

You don't have to invent your values from nothing, because they show up in your strongest reactions. Anger often means that something you care about has been stepped on, envy can point to something you want for yourself, and sadness often shows what you love. Sacha is furious when a colleague takes credit for the team's work. Under the anger is a value, which is fairness and seeing people's effort, and once he names it he can raise fairness at the next team meeting instead of seething at one person for a week. He might say, "I think I'm upset because fairness really matters to me, more than winning this one."

Think of the last time you felt strongly, in a good way or a bad one, and finish the sentence "That mattered to me because I care about…"

03

Two good things can pull in different directions.

Most hard choices are between two good things, such as honesty and kindness, freedom and safety, or family and rest. Feeling torn usually means you care about more than one thing, and even when you choose well it is normal to feel a little sad about the side you didn't choose. A mum cares about being honest and about protecting her eight-year-old. When the family dog is very ill, she finds a way to honour both and tells the truth gently, in words a child can hold. "Biscuit is very poorly. The vet is helping, and we'll look after him together."

If you feel stuck on a choice, write down the good thing on each side. It often helps to ask whether you can honour some of both, even if you can't have all of either.

04

Put your effort where it can land.

About two thousand years ago, a teacher called Epictetus, who had been born into slavery, taught that some things are up to us and some aren't. Your own choices, effort and treatment of other people are up to you, while other people's choices, the weather and the past are not. Worry tends to collect in the second pile, and values do their work in the first. Ingrid wants her partner to enjoy Christmas with her family, and she can't make him enjoy it. She can plan a shorter visit, include a walk on Boxing Day that he will like and be warm herself, and that is her part.

One way to try this is to write a worry in two columns, the parts that are up to you and the parts that aren't, then pick one small thing from the first column and do it.

05

A good life is more than a good mood.

Feeling good matters. Many thinkers, from the Greek philosopher Aristotle to psychologists today, also describe a second kind of wellbeing, which comes from growing, using your strengths, being a good friend and doing things that matter even when they are hard. Aristotle called it flourishing, and he thought we build it the way we build any skill, by practice, a little at a time. Jade spent a month helping a friend move out of a damp, unhappy flat. It was tiring and not much fun, and when she looks back on her year she counts it among the best months of it.

Tonight you might write down one thing that felt good today and one that felt worthwhile, and notice whether they turn out to be the same thing.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If you enjoy big questions, try putting philosophy next to psychology and see what they share. It's one of my favourite rainy-day games.

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Learn by doing: connect two fields of study
spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath

06

Meaning comes from ordinary places.

Researchers who study meaning often describe three parts to it. Your life makes some sense to you, you are heading somewhere, and your life matters to someone. Most meaning comes from people, from work done with care and from small roles that others count on, far more than from big moments. Walter has lived alone since his wife died, and for a long time his days went quiet. Now he reads to children at the library one morning a week, which gives him a reason to iron a shirt on Tuesday nights and a small group of people who notice when he isn't there.

Try listing three roles you play, big or small, such as neighbour, sister or the one who waters the office plants, and next to each one write who it matters to.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Keep your little rituals alive

Lachlan and Sunita, who lead a hybrid team of nine together

Keep your little rituals alive

Person A
Lachlan

Person B
Sunita

Date
2 October 2026

Part A: Our rituals, big and small

Ritual or habit	How often	How it's doing	What it gives us, or what got in the way
Monday coffee call, cameras optional	*Weekly*	*Fading*	*Half the team stopped coming when it moved to 8:30*
Friday "one good thing" round in the team chat	*Weekly*	*Alive*	*Five minutes; people notice each other's work*
A card and lunch when someone leaves	*Now and then*	*Alive*	*People leave feeling thanked*
Office day with lunch together	*Monthly*	*Stopped*	*Stopped when the office moved; the three who work from home felt like guests*
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day	*Daily*	*New idea*	*So nobody wonders who's around*

PART B: WHERE YOUR RITUALS STAND

Your rituals
5 rituals listed. Alive: 2 · Fading: 1 · Stopped: 1 · New idea: 1.

Fading or stopped
Monday coffee call, cameras optional, Office day with lunch together.

New ideas
Hello and goodbye in the chat, start and end of day.

Rituals lapse for ordinary reasons: a new job, a baby, a move, an illness, a hard year. A stopped one isn't a failure. Pick one to restart below, or let it go on purpose.

Part C: One to restart, or start

The ritual
Monday coffee call

The smallest version that still counts
Ten minutes at 9:15, no work talk, cameras optional

The first time: when, and who will suggest it
Next Monday; Sunita sends the invite

What would make it easy to skip, and how we'll protect it (optional)
A busy week. We keep it then too, just shorter.

Part D (optional): One to let go, with thanks

The ritual
Office day with lunch together

What it gave us
A day all together, back when we all lived near the office

The sheet is written for couples and families, and it works for a team: the rituals are what make a group feel like one.

Fill in your own: Keep your little rituals alive

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-15 · free to print
Keep your little rituals alive
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-15

07

Different values aren't wrong values.

Two people can share a home, a family or a team and still put the same good things in a different order, with one putting safety first and another adventure. The philosopher Isaiah Berlin argued that there are many real goods in life and that they can't all be ranked on one scale, which leaves room to disagree without either person being bad. Jasper values a calm, tidy home, and his housemate Darnell values an open door and friends dropping by. For months each privately thought of the other as messy or uptight. Once they named what each of them cared about, they could make a plan, and Friday nights became open house while Sundays stayed quiet.

In your next disagreement, it may help to ask, "What matters to you about this?", and to listen for the value underneath the position.

08

Values live in small, everyday acts.

A good life is built mostly from small things done again and again, such as how you greet people, whether you keep small promises and how you talk about someone who isn't in the room. The Chinese teacher Confucius taught that small, everyday courtesies shape who we become, and later thinkers who wrote about care

said that being good starts with paying attention to the person in front of you. At the supermarket an older man is struggling with the card machine, and the queue behind him is growing. You wait without sighing and tell him there's no rush, which costs you forty seconds.

Pick one value, choose one tiny act that shows it, and do it each day this week. When you drift, you can simply turn back without punishing yourself.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: a value can be as small as a cup of tea made just the way someone likes it. A "What feels like care" card helps you learn what feels like care to each of you.

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: what feels like care
spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can choose your direction, notice when you drift, and turn back without shame. You can't choose other people's values for them, and you don't have to adopt theirs to love them. You can share what matters to you, listen to what matters to them, and look for the places where your directions overlap.

SUNDAY, 9:20PM

You write three words on the back of an envelope, people, health and making things, and under each one a small thing for this week. Call Gran, walk on Wednesday, finish the shelf. The week is still full, and you prop the envelope against the kettle where you will see it in the morning.

In everyday life

Partners may rank the same values differently, such as security and adventure, and it helps to say what each of you is protecting before you argue about the plan. Two generations of a family can both value family and mean quite different things by it, from living close by to being free to go, so it is worth asking what the word means to each of you. When a job keeps asking you to act against a value, the strain often shows up as tiredness or cynicism, and naming the clash is a first step. A club, a faith group or volunteering can give you a place to act on a value alongside other people.

If you want to help someone else with this

Asking "What matters most to you about this?" helps more than telling someone what they ought to care about. People often see their values for the first time in someone else's words, so it can help to notice them out loud, as in "You stayed late to help your friend. Loyalty really matters to you, doesn't it?" With children, naming the value when you see it teaches more than a lecture. Try not to use values as a weapon, because "I thought you valued family" lands as a guilt trip. You can disagree with someone's choice and still see the good thing they were reaching for.

YOU COULD SAY

"What would a good outcome look like to you?" "What do you want to be able to say about how you handled this, a year from now?"

When to get more help

Feeling a bit lost or flat for a while is part of being human. But some signs mean it's worth talking to someone trained:

- Life has felt empty or pointless for more than two weeks, and things you used to enjoy don't reach you. That can be depression, which is common and treatable. A doctor or counsellor is a good first step.
- You have thoughts of not wanting to be alive. Please talk to someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.
- Someone in your life is pushing you to give up what matters to you, cutting you off from friends, or making you afraid to disagree. That's about control, not values. The page When it's more than a rough patch (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) can help you think it through.

Some therapies, such as acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), work directly with values. A counsellor can help you find yours when everything feels foggy.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
When it's more than a rough patch
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Your self-discovery path, step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud.

A limit to keep in mind: This chapter shares ideas to think with, not answers to follow. Your values are yours to find, and it's fine if they change as your life does.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

More for your situation

- **On your own after a big change:** On my own · Empty nest · A new chapter after loss
- **Couples with different priorities:** Money together

- **Families with different beliefs:** Two faiths, one family · Coming out as an adult
- **Friends and work:** Friends · At work
- **Teens working out who they are:** For teens · Growing up
- Find your own starting point: Help by relationship.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Empty nest
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

ONLINE
A new chapter after loss
spreadloveandacceptance.com/grief

ONLINE
Money together
spreadloveandacceptance.com/money-together

ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance.com/two-faiths

ONLINE
Coming out as an adult
spreadloveandacceptance.com/coming-out

ONLINE
Friends
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends

TOOL
Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round
spreadloveandacceptance.com/work

ONLINE
For teens
spreadloveandacceptance.com/teens

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance.com/by-relationship

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 1, Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
Turning values into one small goal

Know Yourself Kindly, page 45

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
Two kinds of fair
Share the Load, page 71

Book 3, Chapter 6 · Groups, influence and culture
Whose values a group rewards
Understanding Each Other, page 101

Book 1, Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion
Worth that is not a score
Know Yourself Kindly, page 81

PUT IT TO USE

Your self-discovery path
Step by step, and Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, if you want to think out loud
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-10-values-in-depth

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

How do I tell ordinary stress from something that needs help?

Stress that comes and goes with what is happening, and eases when the pressure lifts, is part of life. When it hangs on after the pressure has gone, or sleep, appetite and mood stay off for weeks, it is worth a word with your doctor. Every chapter in this book has a short part called "When to get more help", and Stress and the nervous system (Chapter 1, page **9**) is a good place to begin.

I lost my temper and said something I regret. Is it too late to put it right?

It rarely is. A short apology that names what you did, without a "but", and a plan for next time go a long way, even days later. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page **89**) shows how a repair goes, and Anger (Chapter 2, page **31**) has a pause plan for the next time the heat rises.

Someone I love is grieving. What should I say?

Something simple and true, such as "I don't know what to say, but I'm here." Saying the name of the person who died is usually a kindness. Practical help, like a meal, a lift or a walk, often means more than the right words, and so does still being there a few months on. Loss, grief and big life changes (Chapter 4, page **73**) has more.

I keep starting good habits and dropping them. What am I doing wrong?

Probably nothing, except starting too big. Habits stick when the first step is tiny, tied to something you already do and easy to restart after a missed day. Habits and change (Chapter 6, page **107**) shows how to shrink a step until it takes two minutes or less.

Do I have to forgive someone who hurt me?

No. Forgiveness, trust and going back are all yours to choose, in your own time, and you can heal even if the other person never says sorry. Healing after hurt (Chapter 5, page **89**) explains what forgiving means and what it doesn't.

Where can I find help quickly?

The help page at the front of this book (page **7**) has the numbers to call, including in an emergency. For everything else, Help beyond this book lists counsellors, helplines and support groups, and most of them are free.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Help beyond this book
spreadloveandacceptance.com/outside-help

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool this book points to, in two separate lists, with the chapters and pages that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9)

WORKPAPER WP-03 **One owner per job** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-03

In: Habits and change (page 107)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Anger (page 31), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 51)

WORKPAPER WP-13 **The 90-second daily check-in** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-13

In: Habits and change (page 107)

WORKPAPER WP-15 **Keep your little rituals alive** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-15

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 125)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

In: Healing after hurt (page 89)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: make a pause plan** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/pursue-withdraw

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9)

TOOL **Small wins: Flip it** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

In: Worry, low mood and trauma (page 51)

TOOL **How you connect: what feels like care** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/love-languages

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 125)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 125)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Anger (page 31), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 51), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 73), Healing after hurt (page 89), Habits and change (page 107)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: soften a tense moment** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/tools/soften-a-tense-moment

In: Anger (page 31)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: calm sounds and music** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/soundscapes

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Worry, low mood and trauma (page 51), Loss, grief and big life changes (page 73)

TOOL **My weather today: the sky (the ladder)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

In: Stress and the nervous system (page 9), Healing after hurt (page 89)

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

In: Loss, grief and big life changes (page 73), Healing after hurt (page 89)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page 125)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

In: Habits and change (page 107)

TOOL **Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting`

In: Healing after hurt (page **89**)

TOOL **Team job list: the 10-minute weekly round** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/work`

In: Anger (page **31**), Worry, low mood and trauma (page **51**), Habits and change (page **107**), Values, meaning and a good life (page **125**)

TOOL **Learn by doing: connect two fields of study** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/polymath`

In: Values, meaning and a good life (page **125**)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, how full your stress tank is: a fuller tank means a lower battery.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Complacency
Complacency is what happens when something has worked for a long time and you stop checking on it. It isn't laziness or a lack of love. It's a setup nobody has looked at lately.

Drift
Drift is how two people slowly fall out of step when nobody checks in, even when nothing is wrong.

Flooded
Flooded means being so wound up that listening stops working for a while. The kind thing is a short pause with a time to come back.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

Kinship care
When a grandparent, aunt, older sibling or family friend raises a child whose parents can't.

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking
Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Person A and Person B

Person A and Person B are simply the two people on a two-person worksheet or tool. They are labels, not a ranking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Prolonged grief

Grief that stays intense and gets in the way of daily life for a long time after a death (6 to 12 months or more, depending on the guideline). It is treatable; a GP or doctor is a good first step.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

Setup score

The one number from Is the setup working for everyone?: balance, ownership and stress added up with weights (0.40, 0.35 and 0.25), from 0 to 1. 0.70 and up is working well, 0.40 to 0.69 needs a look, under 0.40 needs a rethink, together. It judges the setup, never a person.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is light, 0.30 to 0.59 medium, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes



The 149 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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